

Malayalam, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Malayalam one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Malayalam letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read **നമസ്കാരം** *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Malayalam simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Malayalam is the youngest of the four literary **Dravidian** languages — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit — and it is the **closest sister of Tamil**, having split from it only about a thousand years ago. That double nature runs through this book: its everyday core is strikingly Tamil-like (“thanks” is **നന്ദി** *nandi*, twin of Tamil *nanri*; “no” is **ഇല്ല** *illa*, twin of Tamil *illai*), while a vast Sanskrit layer — the old *Maṇipravāḷam* tradition mixed the two freely — gives it a Sanskrit formal greeting (**നമസ്കാരം**) and the largest alphabet of the family. Each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Malayalam out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in

brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Malayalam greetings and the words that oil a first conversation — and, taught through them, how to read the Malayalam script and how Malayalam sits inside the Dravidian family. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/ML-C01-*.md.*

1.1 നമസ്കാരം (*namaskāram*) — “greetings,” a making of a bow

The letters in this word

Malayalam reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” ന na, മ ma, ര ra. A **vowel sign** changes it: ക ka + long-ā → കാ kā. The *chandrakkala* strips a vowel so consonants **join as a conjunct**: സ + ക → സ്ക “ska.” The **anusvāram** ണ adds a final nasal “-m.” Read ന·മ·സ്കാ·ര·ം → *namaskāram*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നമസ്കാരം (*namaskāram*) is **Sanskrit**: *namas* (“a bow”) + *kāra* (“a making,” root *kr*, “to do”), with a Malayalam ending = “the making of a bow.” The same word as Hindi *namaskār*. Worth marking, because Malayalam is otherwise the **closest sister of Tamil** — the two split only about a thousand years ago — yet it absorbed an enormous Sanskrit layer (the old *Maṇipravāḷam* style mixed the two freely), so its formal greeting is Sanskrit even as its everyday core stays deeply Tamil-like.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Hello”	Source
Malayalam	നമസ്കാരം <i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Kannada	<i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
Tamil	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Even Tamil’s closest sister took the Sanskrit greeting; Tamil alone kept its own.

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. Both **hello** and **goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone.

1.2 നന്ദി (*nandi*) — “thank you,” and the Tamil kinship made visible

The letters in this word

ന is *na*; ി is “ndi” — a **conjunct** of ന (*na*) + ി (*da*) into “nd,” with the “i” sign. Read ന·ി → *nandi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നന്ദി (*nandi*) is **native Dravidian**, from the same root *nal* / *nan* (“good”) as Tamil *nan̄ri*. Malayalam and Tamil split from one language about a thousand years ago, so their oldest words are near-twins — “thanks” is a perfect case: Malayalam *nandi*, Tamil *nan̄ri*. Meanwhile Kannada and Telugu use the Sanskrit *dhanyavāda*, so the map of “thanks” traces the family’s fault-line exactly.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Malayalam	നന്ദി <i>nandi</i>	native (root <i>nal</i>)
Tamil	<i>nanri</i>	the <i>same</i> native root
Kannada	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād / shukriyā</i>	Sanskrit / Perso-Arabic

Tamil and Malayalam on the native side; Kannada and Telugu on the Sanskrit side.

1.3 അതെ (*athe*) — “yes,” literally “that [is so]”

The letters in this word

അ is the **independent vowel** “a” (word-initial). തെ is “the” — ത (*tha*, a soft *th*) with the “e” sign, which is written *in front* of its consonant but read after. Read അതെ → *athe*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

അതെ (*athe*) is native Malayalam, grown from അത് (*athu*), “that.” To say “yes,” Malayalam essentially says “**that [is so]**,” affirming by pointing at the truth of what was said. Its partner is *alla*, “[it is] not that.”

Grammar Lens

Malayalam’s yes/no are demonstratives in disguise: *athe* (“that [is so]”) vs. *alla* (“not that”). Like its sisters, Malayalam also answers by **echoing the verb** (*vannu*, “[I] came,” for “did you come?”). You agree by confirming *that* is how things are.

1.4 ഇല്ല (*illa*) — “no,” shared almost exactly with Tamil

The letters in this word

ഇ is the independent vowel “i” (word-initial). ള് is “lla” — a conjunct of ല (la) + ല (la), a held “ll.” Read ഇല്ല → *illa*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഇല്ല (*illa*) is built on the ancient Dravidian root *il*, “not-being” — so, exactly like Tamil *illai*, it means “[it] is not, [there] is not,” serving as the everyday “no.” Its positive twin is ഉണ്ട് (*untũ*), “there is.”

Grammar Lens

Dravidian negates by *being*. Where English inserts *not*, Malayalam — like Tamil and Kannada — swaps in the negative verb of existence: *pustakam untũ* (“there is a book”) → *pustakam illa* (“there is not a book”). Strongest across the Tamil–Malayalam pair: Tamil *illai*, Malayalam *illa*, Kannada *illa* (Telugu was the outlier, with *lēdu*).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“No / isn’t”	Note
Malayalam	ഇല്ല <i>illa</i>	native, root <i>il</i> -
Tamil	<i>illai</i>	the <i>same</i> root
Kannada	<i>illa</i>	the <i>same</i> root
Telugu	<i>lēdu</i>	native, a <i>different</i> root
Hindi	<i>nahī</i>	Indo-European (unrelated)

1.5 ശരി (śari) — “okay,” the whole-family word once more

The letters in this word

ശ is “śa” (a *sh*-sound). Having borrowed so much Sanskrit, Malayalam keeps the full set of Sanskrit sibilants (ś, ṣ, s) as separate letters — more than Tamil, which uses one. ി is *ri*. Read ശരി → śari.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ശരി (śari) is the pan-Dravidian “correct, right” → “okay, agreed” — the verbal nod of Malayalam. The same family word as Tamil and Kannada *sari* and Telugu *sarē*; Malayalam just spells its opening sound with ശ (ś). Doubled, śari śari = “fine, fine.”

Grammar Lens

One word, four scripts. *sari* / *sarē* / *śari* is the clearest single proof of how close these four languages are: one word, one meaning, four different scripts. Catching a shared word change its clothes but not its sense is the fastest way to feel the whole family at once — the reason to learn the four side by side.

1.6 Recap, and how Malayalam says goodbye

Read		Meaning	Origin
നമസ്കാരം	<i>namaskāram</i>	hello	Sanskrit
നന്ദി	<i>nandi</i>	thank you	native (= Tamil <i>nan̄ri</i>)
അതെ	<i>athe</i>	yes	native (“that is so”)
ഇല്ല	<i>illa</i>	no / isn’t	native (= Tamil <i>illai</i>)
ശരി	<i>śari</i>	okay	native (= <i>sari</i>)

How **Tamil-like** the native core is: four of the five everyday words are shared with Tamil — because Malayalam is Tamil’s closest sister — while only the formal greeting reached for Sanskrit.

Why it's said this way

Nearly the Tamil words exactly. Malayalam, too, will not say a bare “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varām*), “having gone, I [will] come [back]” — set beside Tamil’s *pōy varugirēn* and Kannada’s *hōgi baruttēne*: the same sentence, the same worldview, and in Malayalam and Tamil almost the same *words*.

That completes the four Dravidian first chapters. Next chapter: introducing yourself — *enre pēru...* (“my name...”) — and Malayalam’s *nī* / *ninnīl* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

എന്റെ പേര് അരുൺ ആണ്. (*enre pēru Arun āṇṁ* — “My name is Arun.”)

നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? (*ninre pēru entāṇṁ* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/ML-C02-*.md.*

2.1 പേര് (*pēru*) — “name,” the native Dravidian word

The letters in this word

പ (*pa*) + േ (the *ē*-sign) → പേ (*pē*); ൾ (bare *r*, with the chandrakkala).
Read പേര് → *pēru*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പേര് (*pēru*, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian **pēr* — the *same* word as Tamil *peyar* and Telugu *pēru*, a cousin of Kannada *hesaru* (*p*→*h*). Being Tamil’s closest sister, Malayalam naturally keeps the native word, *not* the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*).

2.2 എന്റെ (*enre*) — “my”

The letters in this word

എ (independent *e*) + the conjunct െന്റെ (*nre*) → *enre*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എന്റെ (*enre*, “my”) is the possessive of ഞാൻ (*ñān*, “I”) — native Dravidian, the same pronoun stem behind Tamil *nān* / *eṇ*. No Indo-European cousin.

2.3 ആണ് (*āṇṁ*) — “is,” where Malayalam breaks with its sisters

The letters in this word

ആ (independent long *ā*) + ണ് (bare retroflex *ṇ*) → *āṇṁ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ആണ് (*āṇṁ*, “is”) is Malayalam’s **copula** — a real word for “is,” grown from the verb ആക (*āka*, “to be, to become”). Here is the surprise: Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu all use the **zero copula** — no word for “is” at all — yet Malayalam, though it is Tamil’s *closest* sister, went its own way and grammaticalised a “to be” verb. So where Tamil says only *eṇ peyar Arun*, Malayalam adds *āṇṁ*: *enre pēru Arun āṇṁ*.

2.4 എന്റെ പേര് ...ആണ് (*enre pēru ...āṇṁ*) — “my name is...”

എന്റെ (my) + പേര് (name) + name + ആണ് (is) = *enre pēru ...āṇṁ*.
Enre pēru Arun āṇṁ. = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

The verb comes last — as in Hindi (*hai*) and unlike Tamil’s verbless sentence. Malayalam is subject–object–*verb*, and the copula *āṇṁ* closes the sentence: “my name Arun *is*.” (In fast speech Malayalis sometimes drop *āṇṁ*, but the full, correct form keeps it.)

2.5 നീ / നിങ്ങൾ (*nī* / *nin̄ṇaḷ*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The letters in this word

നീ (*nī*); നിങ്ങൾ (*nin̄ṇaḷ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നീ (*nī*, familiar “you”) ← Proto-Dravidian **nīn* — the same native root as Tamil *nī*, Kannada *nīnu*, Telugu *nuvvu*. നിങ്ങൾ (*nin̄ṇaḷ*) is the respectful/plural “you” — *nī* + a plural ending, the exact cousin of Tamil *nīṅgaḷ*.

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural, once more. *nī* (familiar) vs. *nin̄ṇaḷ* (respectful, literally plural) — the family’s shared politeness-by-plural, and the same idea as French *vous*. For a first meeting, *nin̄ṇaḷ*.

2.6 എന്ത് (*entŭ*) — “what”

The letters in this word

എ (*e*) + the conjunct ന്ത് (*ntŭ*) → *entŭ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എന്ത് (*entŭ*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem **yā-*/**e-* — the same Dravidian question-root as Tamil *eṇṇa* and Telugu *ēmiṭi*, heading Malayalam’s question family: *entŭ* (what), *ār* (who),

evite (where), *entāṇṭ* (why).

2.7 നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? (*ninre pēru entāṇṭ*) — “what’s your name?”

നിന്റെ (*ninre*, “your”) is the possessive of *nī* (“you”). And watch the last word: *entāṇṭ* is *entū* (what) + *āṇṭ* (is), fused — so നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? is literally “**your name what is?**” Unlike the Tamil question (which had *no* verb), Malayalam’s carries its copula *āṇṭ* right inside the question-word.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *Enre pēru Arun āṇṭ*. The respectful “your” is *ninnāḷṭe*: *ninnāḷṭe pēru entāṇṭ*?

2.8 സന്തോഷം (*santōṣam*) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is നിങ്ങളെ കണ്ടതിൽ സന്തോഷം (*ninnāḷe kaṇḍatil santōṣam*) — “**joy at having seen you.**” The word സന്തോഷം (*santōṣam*, “joy”) is **Sanskrit** — the same loan Kannada and Telugu use. So even Malayalam, the great keeper of native words (recall *nandi* for “thanks”), reaches for Sanskrit here: the loan words spread *selectively*, word by word, which is exactly what these lessons trace.

2.9 The whole exchange

Malayalam		English
എന്റെ പേര് മീരാ ആണ്.	<i>enre pēru Mira āṇṭ</i>	My name is Mira.
നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്?	<i>ninre pēru entāṇṭ</i>	What’s your name?
എന്റെ പേര് അരുൺ ആണ്.	<i>enre pēru Arun āṇṭ</i>	My name is Arun.
സന്തോഷം.	<i>santōṣam</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *pēru* (Dravidian *pēr, *not name*), *enre* (from *ñān*, “I”), *entŭ* (Dravidian question-stem), *santōṣam* (Sanskrit). And the Malayalam standout: it *has* a copula *āṇŭ* (“is”), where its Dravidian sisters use none. Next chapter: *sukhamāṇō?* (“are you well?”) — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and Malayalam, unlike its sisters, asks it with a real verb “to be”:

സുഖമാണോ? (*sukhamāṇō* — “Are you well? / How are you?”)
സുഖമാണ്, നന്ദി. (*sukhamāṇŭ, nandi* — “I’m well, thank you.”)

Practice lessons: *lessons/ML-C03-*.md*.

3.1 എങ്ങനെ (*eṇṇane*) — “how,” another of the e- questions

The letters in this word

എ (*e*) + ണ് (*ṇṇa*, a doubled velar nasal) + നെ (*ne*) → എങ്ങനെ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എങ്ങനെ (*eṇṇane*, “how”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative base *e-* from *entŭ*. Malayalam gathers its questions here: *entŭ* (what), *eṇṇane* (how), *āṇŭ* (who), *eviṭe* (where), *eppōl* (when). It is the same Dravidian question-root heading Tamil’s *eppaṭi* — the most native layer of a language otherwise rich in Sanskrit.

3.2 സുഖമാണോ? — “are you well?”

സുഖം (*sukham*, “well-being”) + ആണ് (*āṇŭ*, “is,” from Chapter 2) + the question-marker ഓ (*ō*) → സുഖമാണോ — “is [it] well?” Where English says “how are you?”, Malayalam more often asks “are you well?”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The word സുഖം (*sukham*, “well-being, comfort”) is a **Sanskrit** loan — *sukha* = *su-* (“good, well,” the Greek *eu-*) + *kha*. Onto it Malayalam adds its **native** copula *āṇṅ* and the question particle *-ō*: a Sanskrit noun, a Dravidian verb — Malayalam in miniature.

Grammar Lens

-ō makes a yes/no question. Add ഒ (*-ō*) to the end of a statement: *sukham āṇṅ* (“it is well”) → *sukham āṇṅō*? (“is it well?”). No word-order change, no helper — just the little *-ō*.

3.3 ഞാൻ (*ñān*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

The letters in this word

ഞ (*ña*, a palatal nasal like “ny,” at the very start) + ാ (long *ā*) +ൻ (the word-final *n*, a *chillu*) → ഞാൻ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഞാൻ (*ñān*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian **yān* / **ñān* — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *main*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the എന്റെ (*enre*, “my”) from Chapter 2.

Grammar Lens

Malayalam does not drop “I.” Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu verbs carry the person in their ending, so they freely drop the pronoun. But Malayalam verbs *do not change for person at all* (Chapter 5) — so *ñān* must be said; the verb won’t tell you who acts.

3.4 സുഖം (*sukham*) — “well-being,” and how to answer

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സുഖം (*sukham*, “well-being, comfort, ease”) is a **Sanskrit** loan, the *su-* of Greek *eu-*. Where Tamil answers “how are you?” with native *nalam*, Malayalam — Tamil’s closest sister, but far deeper in Sanskrit — reaches for *sukham*. The reply, with the copula: സുഖമാണ് (*sukhamāṇ*), “[I am] well,” reusing the greeting’s own words without the question *-ō*.

3.5 സാരമില്ല (*sāramilla*) — “it doesn’t matter”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സാരമില്ല means “**there’s no matter to it**” — used for “never mind / no worries / you’re welcome.” A perfect emblem of Malayalam: സാരം (*sāram*, “substance, essence”) is **Sanskrit**, while ഇല്ല (*illa*, “is not”) is the **native** Dravidian negative from Chapter 1. Sanskrit noun, Dravidian verb, one word. That *illa* is shared across **Malayalam, Tamil, and Kannada** (Telugu alone diverges, to *lēdu*).

Grammar Lens

Illa negates existence and stands alone as “no”: *paṇam illa* (“there’s no money”). It is the negative twin of the copula *āṇ* (“is”) — *āṇ* affirms, *illa* denies.

3.6 The whole exchange

Malayalam	English
സുഖമാണോ?	Are you well? / How are you?
സുഖമാണ്, നന്ദി.	I’m well, thank you.
സാരമില്ല.	It doesn’t matter / you’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *erīṇane* (the native *e-* questions), *ñāṇ* (Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*), *sukham* (Sanskrit “well,” the *su-* of Greek

eu-), and the *āñũ* / *illa* pair — “is” and “is-not,” the *illa* shared with Tamil and Kannada. Next chapter: the farewells — and Malayalam, like all its family, never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Malayalam, like every Dravidian language, does not say a plain “goodbye.” It promises to return:

പോയി വരാം. (*pōyi varāṇ* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/ML-C04-.md.*

4.1 പോകുക (*pōkuka*) — “to go,” and വരിക (to come)

The letters in this word

പോ (*pō*) + കുക (*kuka*, the *-uka* infinitive) → പോകുക. Its partner വരിക (*varika*, “to come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പോകുക (*pōkuka*, “to go”) and വരിക (*varika*, “come”) are native Dravidian verbs. The ending *-ക* (*-uka*) is how Malayalam names a verb in the dictionary — its “to ...” form (where Tamil uses a bare stem). You need both, because the Malayalam goodbye is “I go, and I come back.”

4.2 പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varāṇ*) — “I’ll go and come back”

പോയി (*pōyi*, “having gone”) + വരാം (*varāṇ*, “I’ll come”) — literally

“having gone, I’ll come [back],” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Malayali never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving.” The warm reply is പോയി വരൂ (*pōyi varū*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varāṇ</i>
Tamil	<i>pōy varugirēṇ</i>
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Telugu	<i>velli vastānu</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)

The whole south, and beyond, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

Grammar Lens

The -ആം ending, “I will / let me.” *-āṇ* on a verb stem is a soft, volitional future: *varāṇ* (“I’ll come”), *kāṇāṇ* (“let’s see,” next lesson), *ceyyāṇ* (“I’ll do it”).

4.3 നാളെ കാണാം (*nāḷe kāṇāṇ*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

നാളെ (*nāḷe*): നാ (*nā*) + ളെ (*ḷe*, retroflex ഉ *ḷ*). കാണാം (*kāṇāṇ*) = കാണ (*kāṇ* “see”) + *-āṇ* (“let’s”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നാളെ (*nāḷe*, “tomorrow”) is native, from *nāl* (“day”) — the same root as Tamil’s *nālai* and Kannada’s *nāḷe*. കാണുക (*kāṇuka*, “to see”) gives *kāṇāṇ* — so the phrase is “tomorrow, let’s see [each other].”

4.4. വീണ്ടും കാണാം (VĪṆṬUM KĀṆĀM) — “WE’LL MEET AGAIN”¹⁹

4.4 വീണ്ടും കാണാം (*vīṇṭum kāṇām*) — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

വീണ്ടും കാണാം = വീണ്ടും (*vīṇṭum*, “again”) + *kāṇām* (“let’s see”). Both native Dravidian: *vīṇṭum* (“again,” from *vīṇṭu*, “to return”) and *kāṇ* (“to see”). Where Tamil’s “we’ll meet again” reaches for the Sanskrit loan *sandi* to say “meet,” Malayalam — like Kannada — keeps its own native verb.

4.5 The farewells

Malayalam	English
പോയി വരാം.	I’ll go and come back. (goodbye)
പോയി വരൂ.	Go and come back. (the reply)
നാളെ കാണാം.	See you tomorrow.
വീണ്ടും കാണാം.	We’ll meet again.

Roots banked: *pōkuka/varika* (go/come), *nāḷe* (“tomorrow” ← *nāl* “day,” shared with Tamil & Kannada), *kāṇ* (“to see”), and the *-ām* “I will” ending. Next chapter: the first real verbs — *ñāṇ malayāḷaṇ saṁsārikkunnu* — and Malayalam’s one astonishing simplicity.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and the one astonishingly simple thing about Malayalam grammar:

ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു. (*ñāṇ malayāḷaṁ saṁsārikkunnu* — “I speak Malayalam.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/ML-C05-.md.*

5.1 സംസാരിക്കുക (*saṁsārikkuka*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

സം (*saṁ*) + സാ (*sā*) + രി (*ri*) + ക്കുക (*kkuka*) → സംസാരിക്കുക.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സംസാരിക്കുക (*saṁsārikkuka*, “to speak, converse”) is Sanskrit-derived (from *saṁsāra*, “flowing together”), beside the native *parayuka* (“to say”) — another sign of Malayalam’s deep Sanskrit layer. To say “I speak,” add the present ending -ഉന്നു (*-unnu*) to the stem: *saṁsārikk-* + *-unnu* → സംസാരിക്കുന്നു (*saṁsārikkunnu*).

Grammar Lens

The verb never changes for person. In Tamil, Telugu, and Kannada the verb changes ending for *who* acts. *Malayalam does not.* It is the same for everyone:

ñān saṃsārikkunnu (I speak) *nī saṃsārikkunnu* (you speak) *avan saṃsārikkunnu* (he speaks)

One form, all persons — which is exactly why (Chapter 3) Malayalam can never drop the pronoun. Of all its Dravidian sisters, Malayalam went the furthest here.

5.2 ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു — “I speak Malayalam”

ഞാൻ (I) + മലയാളം (*malayāḷam*, the object) + സംസാരിക്കുന്നു (speak) — “I Malayalam speak,” the verb last. The name മലയാളം (*malayāḷam*) is native Dravidian: *mala* (“mountain”) + *āḷam* (“place, region”) — “**the mountain land**,” for the Western Ghats along its coast. The signature retroflex *ള* (*ḷ*) sits in the middle of the word.

Grammar Lens

Because *saṃsārikkunnu* is the same for every person, the pronoun ഞാൻ (*ñān*) cannot be dropped — it is the only thing marking “I.”

5.3 താമസിക്കുക (*tāmasikkuka*) — “to live, to stay”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

താമസിക്കുക (*tāmasikkuka*, “to live, reside, stay”) is Sanskrit-derived (from *tāmasa*, “dwelling”); Malayalam often prefers such Sanskrit-built verbs where Tamil uses a native word (*vāḷ*). “I live in Kochi” is ഞാൻ കൊച്ചിയിൽ താമസിക്കുന്നു (*ñān kocchiyil tāmasikkunnu*) — the same *-unnu* present, the same for every person.

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. കൊച്ചിയിൽ (*kocchiyil*) = *Kochi* + *-il* (“in”), on the noun’s *end*. Malayalam uses **postpositions**: “Kochi-in I live,” verb last, pronoun kept.

5.4 ജോലി ചെയ്യുക (*jōli ceyyuka*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ചെയ്യുക (*ceyyuka*, “to do, make”) is core native Dravidian — the *same root* as Tamil *sey*. Like Hindi’s *karnā*, Tamil’s *sey*, Telugu’s *cēyu*, and Kannada’s *māḍu*, Malayalam builds compounds with it: ജോലി ചെയ്യുക (*jōli ceyyuka*, “work-do” = “to work”). So “I work” is ഞാൻ ജോലി ചെയ്യുന്നു (*ñān jōli ceyyunnu*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + ചെയ്യുക = a new verb — the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*, Tamil’s *sey*, Telugu’s *cēyu*, Kannada’s *māḍu*. Five languages, two from an unrelated family, one shared trick.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Malayalam	English
ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു.	I speak Malayalam.
ഞാൻ കൊച്ചിയിൽ താമസിക്കുന്നു.	I live in Kochi.
ഞാൻ ജോലി ചെയ്യുന്നു.	I work.

Three verbs, one endlessly simple engine: the *-unnu* present, the verb always last, the same for every person — so the pronoun always stays. Roots banked: *saṃsārikkuka* (Sanskrit; native twin *parayuka*), *tāmasikkuka* (Sanskrit; where Tamil uses native *vāḷ*), *ceyyuka* (the *same root* as Tamil *sey*), and *malayāḷaṇ* = “the mountain land.” From here, Malayalam’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Case Endings and Dative Subjects

6.1 -ിക്കു (-ikku) — “to, for”

Your first **case ending**. English puts “to” in **front** as its own word. Malayalam sticks it on the **back** — and that is the biggest structural fact about the language.

What to know first

word	+ dative	meaning
പേര് <i>pēru</i> — name	പേരിന് <i>pērinu</i>	to/for the name
ജോലി <i>jōli</i> — work	ജോലിക്കു <i>jōlikku</i>	for work

Malayalam’s dative has two shapes — **-ിക്കു** *-ikku* and **-ിന്** *-inu* — chosen by the sound the noun ends in. Same case, same job; the seam is still visible.

And with “I”, which reshapes first:

ഞാൻ *ñān* (“I”) → എനിക്ക് *enikku* (“to me”)

Learn *enikku* cold — it opens a great many everyday Malayalam sentences, as the next lesson shows.

Why it's said this way

	Malayalam -ikku	a Latin ending like -īs
pins down the case?	yes — dative, always	no — <i>-īs</i> is dative or ablative
carries number?	no — a separate suffix does	yes — plural, baked in
carries declension class?	no	yes — 1st/2nd only
can you see the seam?	yes: <i>jōli + kku</i>	no — one fused lump

Malayalam **stacks**: each suffix means one thing and sits in a fixed order — so a long word can be read piece by piece. Latin **fuses**: *-īs* is case *and* plural *and* declension at once, indivisible, and it doesn't even settle *which* case. Malayalam's dative is never ambiguous.

That's what “**agglutinative**” means, and why Malayalam words grow long without growing hard: they are **built**, not memorised.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*pēru ... pērinu*”
- “*ñān ... enikku*” — “I” ... “to me”
- “*jōlikku*” — “for work,” from Ch. 5's ജോലി
- the principle — “one suffix, one meaning, visible seam”

Before you move on

What does **-ിക്കു** mean? (“**To**” or “**for**.”) Where does it go? (**On the end** of the noun.) What is “to me”? (**എനിക്ക്** *enikku*.) Why does the suffix have two shapes? (**-ikku** and **-inu** are chosen by the noun's ending — one case, two forms.) How is that unlike a Latin ending? (Latin **fuses** case+number+declension — and *-īs* doesn't even fix *which* case; Malayalam's carries **one** meaning, unambiguously, seam visible.) Next: the sentence where the person isn't the subject.

6.2 എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം — “I know Malayalam”

Chapter 5 gave you ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു — “I speak Malayalam.” Now say “I **know** Malayalam.” Malayalam will not let you use *ñān*.

What to know first

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം. *enikku malayālam ariyām*. literally: “**to-me** Malayalam is-knowable.”

piece

എനിക്ക് <i>enikku</i>	“to me” — the dative from the last lesson
മലയാളം <i>malayālam</i>	Malayalam (Ch. 5)
അറിയാം <i>ariyām</i>	“can be known” — <i>ariy-</i> “know” + <i>-ām</i> , the <i>able-to</i> ending

You are not the subject. *Ñān* is gone; the person has been moved into the dative, and the sentence is now about the **language**. Malayalam isn’t saying you perform an act of knowing — it’s saying the language is knowable **to you**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Malayalam separates what you **do** from what **happens to** you. Speaking is an action, so Ch. 5 used *ñān*. But knowing, liking, wanting, being hungry — these **arrive** at you. Malayalam marks that by putting the person in the **dative**.

English frames it as	Malayalam frames it as
I know Malayalam	Malayalam is known to me
I like it	it is pleasing to me
I am cold	cold is to me

English preserves one fossil of exactly this: “**methinks**” — *me* is a dative, “it seems **to me**.” Malayalam made it the rule.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

language	“I know [the language]”	the dative
Malayalam	<i>enikku malayālam</i> <i>ariyām</i>	-ikku
Tamil	<i>enakku tamīl teriyum</i>	-ukku
Telugu	<i>nāku telugu vaccu</i>	-ku
Kannada	<i>nanage kannada gottu</i>	-ge

Look at the first column: Malayalam’s *enikku* and Tamil’s *enakku* are nearly the **same word** — the two languages separated most recently of the four, and it shows. One construction, four languages, four visibly related suffixes: the Dravidian family showing its bones, as *blanc/bianco/branco* did for Romance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*enikku malayālam ariyām*”
- the contrast — “*ñān malayālam samisārikkunnu*” (I speak) ... “*enikku malayālam ariyām*” (known to me)
- the near-twins — “*enikku ... enakku*”
- the four cousins — “*-ikku · -ukku · -ku · -ge*”

Before you move on

What does എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം literally say? (“**To-me** Malayalam **is-knowable**.”) What has English got that Malayalam hasn’t? (A nominative “**I**” — *ñān* is replaced by the dative *enikku*.) Why the dative? (Knowing **happens to** you.) Which Tamil word is *enikku* almost identical to, and why? (**Enakku** — Tamil and Malayalam split most recently of the four.) Which English word keeps the same idea? (**Methinks**.)

Chapter 7

Numbers One to Ten

7.1 ഒന്ന്, രണ്ട്, മൂന്ന്, നാല്, അഞ്ച് — one to five

Of all the Dravidian cousins, Malayalam is Tamil's closest — they were one language a thousand years ago — and its numbers show it.

What to know first

	numeral	word	said
1	൧	ഒന്ന്	<i>onnu</i>
2	൨	രണ്ട്	<i>raṇṭu</i>
3	൩	മൂന്ന്	<i>mūnnu</i>
4	൪	നാല്	<i>nālu</i>
5	൫	അഞ്ച്	<i>añcu</i>

The symbols ൧ ൨ ൩ ൪ ൫ are Malayalam's own digits.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Where Telugu breaks the family with *okaṭi*, Malayalam stays loyal: its **one** is *onnu*, the direct cousin of Tamil *onru* (both from the old *on-*). Laid beside Tamil, the whole row is barely changed:

	Tamil	Malayalam
1	<i>onru</i>	onnu
2	<i>iraṇṭu</i>	raṇṭu
3	<i>mūnru</i>	mūnnu
4	<i>nānku</i>	nālu

The one that moved most is **five**: Tamil *aintu* softened its *nt* to a palatal,

giving Malayalam **añcu** — the same shift English feels between *nature* said stiffly and said naturally.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Every word here ends in **chandrakkala** — the little hook ് on the last letter (ഒന്, നാല്) — which trims the final vowel down to a half-heard *ũ*. It's why these read *onn'*, *nāl'* rather than a full *onnu*, *nālu*. And the doubled letters (*onnu*, *mūnnu*) are real **held** consonants — linger on the *nn*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “onnu, raṇṭu, mūnnu, nālu, añcu”
- the near-identity — “onru ↔ onnu”, “iraṇṭu ↔ raṇṭu”
- the one that shifted — “aintu → añcu”

Before you move on

Count to five in Malayalam. (*Onnu, raṇṭu, mūnnu, nālu, añcu*.) Does Malayalam's **one** follow Tamil or break away like Telugu? (**Follows Tamil** — *onnu* ↔ *onru*.) Which number changed most from Tamil, and how? (**Five** — *aintu*'s *nt* palatalised to *añcu*.) What does the **chandrakkala** ് do to a word's last sound? (Trims its vowel to a half-heard *ũ*.) Next: six to ten.

7.2 ആറ്, ഏഴ്, എട്ട്, ഒമ്പത്, പത്ത് — six to ten

Malayalam holds onto a Tamil sound the other cousins let go — and you'll hear it in seven.

What to know first

	numeral	word	said
6	൬	ആറ്	<i>āru</i>
7	൭	ഏഴ്	<i>ēlu</i>
8	൮	എട്ട്	<i>eṭṭu</i>
9	൯	ഒമ്പത്	<i>ompatu</i>
10	൧൦	പത്ത്	<i>pattu</i>

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Watch **seven** travel across the three sister scripts:

	word	its 7-letter
Tamil	<i>ēlu</i>	ലു (l)
Malayalam	<i>ēlu</i>	ഴ (l) — kept
Kannada	<i>ēḷu</i>	ḷ — hardened
Telugu	<i>ēḍu</i>	ḍ — hardened further

Malayalam, alone with Tamil, **keeps the l** — the rare retroflex sound that sits in the name *Tamil* itself. (The name *Malayāḷam*, by contrast, carries the **hardened** cousin **ḷ** — **ള** — the very sound Kannada’s *ēḷu* shows; the two letters **ഴ l** and **ള ḷ** are worth keeping apart.) Six (*āru*), eight (*eṭṭu*) and ten (*pattu*) are likewise almost letter-for-letter Tamil: this is the closest of all the cousin-columns.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Nine comes, exactly as in Tamil, from the old *on* (“one”) + *patu* (“ten”) — one short of ten. But before the *p*, the *n* shifts to an **m**: so the underlying *onpatu* is both **written** ഒമ്പത് and **said** *ompatu* (say “onpatu” fast and you’ll do it yourself). Kannada does the same in *ombattu*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āru, ēlu, eṭṭu, onpatu, pattu”
- seven’s kept sound — “ēlu”, the **l** of *Tamil* (not the **ḷ** of *Malayāḷam*)
- nine taken apart — “on + patu → ompatu”, one short of ten

Before you move on

Count six to ten in Malayalam. (*Āru*, *ēlu*, *eṭṭu*, *onpatu*, *pattu*.) Which sister languages keep Tamil's rare **ḷ** in *seven*, and which hardened it? (**Malayalam keeps it**; Kannada → *ḷ*, Telugu → *ḍ*.) How is *onpatu* built, and why the **m**? (*on* “one” + *patu* “ten”; the *n* becomes *m* before *p*.) Which of these numbers is furthest from Tamil? (None much — this is the closest cousin-set.)

Chapter 8

Please

8.1 ദയവായി (dayavāyi) — please (as a compassion)

Malayalam’s “please” turns compassion into an adverb: do this thing **as a kindness**.

What to know first

ദയവായി = **please**, literally “**kindly / as a compassion**.” Two pieces:

- ദയ (*daya*) = **compassion, kindness, grace** — from Sanskrit **daya**.
- -വായി (*-vāyi*) = “**having become / as**,” turning the noun into “*in the manner of* compassion” — i.e. **kindly**. (The true historical seam is *dayavu* “kindness” + -ആയി *-āyi*, the adverb of ആകുക *ākuka* “to become”; we split it *-vāyi* here just to keep the *daya* root visible.)

So *dayavāyi* asks you to act *kindly, as a kindness*. Where Tamil and Telugu say “**do** the kindness” and Kannada “having **placed** it,” Malayalam makes kindness the **manner** of the whole request.

The family resemblance is unmistakable, and it reaches beyond Dravidian: **Arabic** *min faḍlik* (“from your **grace**”) and **Hindi** *kṛpayā* (from *kṛpā*, “**compassion**”) ask by the same grace-naming instinct.

Why it’s said this way

daya + a light verb, four ways:

- Malayalam ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — compassion + **as / having**

become

- Tamil தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu* — kindness + **do**
- Kannada ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು *dayaviṭṭu* — compassion + **having placed**
- Telugu దయచేసి *dayacēsi* — compassion + **having done**

Why it's said this way

Honestly: as elsewhere in the family, the standalone word is a touch **formal / emphatic**. Everyday Malayalam politeness leans on the **respectful request** form of the verb — endings like -ു (-*ū*) or -ണം (-*aṇam*): ഇരിക്കൂ (*irikkū*) “please sit,” പറയൂ (*parayū*) “please tell me.” Add ദയവായി in front when you want the courtesy spoken aloud.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The heart of the word is വാ — *va* stretched by the **long-ā** sign ാ̄ (-*ā*) — then യി, *ya* + the *i* sign (ി). Malayalam’s rounded letters hang their vowel-signs to the right; the long ാ̄ is simply a tall stroke after the consonant, the same *ā* you would meet across the Dravidian scripts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “daya” — compassion — then “-vāyi,” as / kindly
- the whole word — “dayavāyi” = please
- the everyday way — the verb ending: “irikkū” = please sit

Before you move on

What is the Malayalam word for please? (ദയവായി *dayavāyi*.) What do its pieces mean? (“**Compassion**” *daya* + “as / **having become**” *-vāyi* — *kindly*.) Which cousins ask the same way? (**Tamil, Kannada, Telugu** with *daya* — plus **Arabic** *faḍl*, **Hindi** *kṛpā*.) What carries “please” in ordinary speech? (**The respectful verb form**, endings like -ു -*ū* / -ണം -*aṇam*.)

Chapter 9

Sorry

9.1 ക്ഷമിക്കണം (kṣamikkaṇaṁ) — (you) should forgive / sorry

You already know ദയവായി and the necessitative -ണം ending mentioned there. Malayalam’s “sorry” is that very ending, now carrying a forgiveness-verb.

What to know first

- ക്ഷമ (kṣama) = “**forgiveness, patience**” — the Sanskrit noun.
- -ഇക്കുക (-ikkuka) = a **verb-making suffix**: kṣama + -ikkuka → ക്ഷമിക്കുക (kṣamikkuka), “**to forgive.**”
- -ണം (-aṇaṁ) = the **necessitative** ending, “**must / should**” — literally kṣamikkaṇaṁ says “[you] **must forgive,**” used as a softened, polite request exactly the way English can soften a request into “you should really forgive me” without meaning it as an order.

So ക്ഷമിക്കണം leans on obligation to be polite — a very different move from a plain imperative.

Why it’s said this way

- Malayalam ക്ഷമിക്കണം kṣamikkāṇaṁ — Sanskrit kṣama + -ikkuka (verb) + -aṇaṁ (necessitative: “must/should”)
- Kannada ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ kṣamisi — Sanskrit kṣamā + -isu (verb) + -i (imperative)

- Telugu క్షమించండి *kṣamiṇcaṇḍi* — Sanskrit *kṣamā* + **-iṇcu** (verb) + **-aṇḍi** (imperative)
- Tamil மன்னிக்கவும் *mannikkavum* — its **own** native root *manni*, not Sanskrit at all

Why it's said this way

ക്ഷമിക്കണം is a genuine, common way to ask forgiveness — but Malayalam speakers reach just as often for the plain imperative ക്ഷമിക്കൂ (*kṣamikkū*, using the -ൂ ending from the please lesson) or simply the borrowed English “sorry.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kṣama” — the Sanskrit noun, forgiveness
- the verb — “kṣamikkuka,” to forgive — then “kṣamikkaṇaṁ,” you should forgive
- the plainer version — “kṣamikkū,” using the -ū ending you know

Before you move on

What does ക്ഷമിക്കണം literally say, and why is that polite? (“[You] **must** forgive” — the necessitative **-aṇaṁ** softens an obligation into a request, same as ദയവായി’s note on **-aṇaṁ**.) Which cousins also verb-ify *kṣama*? (**Kannada and Telugu**; Tamil uses its own root *manni*.) What’s a plainer alternative? (**Kṣamikkū**, using the -ū ending, or borrowed English “sorry.”)

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

10.1 തിങ്കൾ to ഞായർ — the week Malayalam shares with Tamil

Malayalam and Tamil are close cousins — they were once, long ago, the same language — and nowhere does that show more clearly than in the words for the days of the week.

What to know first

Malayalam	planet-word	meaning	compare Tamil
തിങ്കളാഴ്ച	<i>thinkaḷ</i>	“Moon”	<i>thingaḷ</i> — nearly identical
ചൊവ്വാഴ്ച	<i>covva</i>	traditionally “the red one”	<i>cevvāy</i> — the same word, worn differently
ബുധനാഴ്ച	<i>budhan</i>	Mercury	Sanskrit Budha , same as Tamil <i>pudhan</i>
വ്യാഴാഴ്ച	<i>vyāzham</i>	Jupiter	matches Tamil’s <i>viyāzhan</i> closely
വെള്ളിയാഴ്ച	<i>velli</i>	traditionally “silver”	<i>velli</i> — the same word
ശനിയാഴ്ച	<i>śani</i>	Saturn	Sanskrit Śani , same as Tamil <i>sani</i>
ഞായറാഴ്ച	<i>ñāyar</i>	“Sun”	<i>ñāyīru</i> — the same root

Why it’s said this way

This is the closest family match you’ll see across this whole course: **thinkaḷ/thingaḷ**, **velli/velli**, and **ñāyar/ñāyīru** are essentially **the same words**, because Malayalam only became a distinct language from Tamil within roughly the last thousand years or so. Where Tamil says കിഴമ (kizhamai) for “day,” Malayalam says ആഴ്ച (āzhcha) — a different word for the same idea (the two aren’t confirmed cognates; treat this as two languages solving the same naming problem separately, not necessarily one shared root). Like Tamil, Malayalam mixes **native** planet-words (Moon, Mars, Venus, Sun) with **Sanskrit** ones (Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn) — the same split, inherited from the same shared ancestor language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “thinkal” — moon — then “āzhcha,” day/week
- the shared words — “velli” (Venus), same in both Malayalam and Tamil
- the Sanskrit ones — “budhan, vyāzham, śani” — Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn

Before you move on

Why do Malayalam and Tamil’s day-names look so alike? (**They were the same language until roughly a thousand years ago.**) Which planet-names does Malayalam share almost word-for-word with Tamil? (**thinkal/Moon, velli/Venus, nāyar/Sun** — and *covva*/Mars, a worn variant of *cevvāy*.) Which three come from Sanskrit in both languages? (**Mercury (Budha), Jupiter (vyāzham/viyāzhan), Saturn (Śani).**)

Chapter 11

Four Core Colours

11.1 കറുപ്പ്, വെള്ള, ചുവപ്പ്, നീല — the same split as Tamil

You’ve seen Malayalam and Tamil share day-names almost word-for-word. Their colors follow the exact same family pattern.

What to know first

- കറുപ്പ് (*karuppŭ*) = “**black**” — matches Tamil *karuppu* almost exactly.
- വെള്ള (*vella*) = “**white**” — the same **vel-** “bright/silvery” root as Tamil *vellai*.
- ചുവപ്പ് (*cuvappŭ*) = “**red**” — a related word from the same Dravidian root family as Tamil *sivappu*, though the two differ in both their opening consonant’s sound and their vowel — a looser cousin than *karuppŭ*/*karuppu* or *vella*/*vellai*, which match almost exactly.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നീല (*nīla*) = “**blue**” — the same **Sanskrit** loan Tamil uses (*nīlam*), and the same one Hindi uses (*nīlā*). Blue is where Malayalam, Tamil, and Hindi all converge on one shared Sanskrit word, even though Malayalam and Tamil otherwise built their own native words for black, white, and red.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “karuppŭ, vellā, cuvappŭ” — black, white, red
- “nīla” — blue, shared with Tamil and Hindi
- the family match — “karuppŭ/karuppu, vellā/vellai, cuvappŭ/sivappu”

Before you move on

Which three Malayalam colors closely match Tamil’s own words? (**Karuppŭ, vellā, cuvappŭ** — black, white, red.) Which color is a shared Sanskrit loan across Malayalam, Tamil, and Hindi? (**Blue** — நீல *nīla* / நீலம் *nīlam* / नीला *nīlā*.)

Chapter 12

Family

12.1 അച്ഛൻ, അമ്മ, and four sibling words — Malayalam’s own set

Malayalam and Tamil share a great deal of their vocabulary — but family words are where Malayalam goes its own way further than you might expect, while still keeping the family’s signature age-first sibling system.

What to know first

- അച്ഛൻ (*acchan*) = “**father**” — a different form from Tamil’s *appā*; **this word’s own deeper origin is less settled** than the simple *appā/amma* pattern, and worth a linguist’s extra look.
- അമ്മ (*amma*) = “**mother**” — matches the family’s shared *amma* pattern closely.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Malayalam	meaning
ചേട്ടൻ (<i>cēṭṭan</i>)	older brother
അനിയൻ (<i>aniyan</i>)	younger brother
ചേച്ചി (<i>cēcci</i>)	older sister
അനിയത്തി (<i>aniyatti</i>)	younger sister

Notice these don’t closely match Tamil/Kannada/Telugu’s *aṇṇan/anna*, *tambi/tammudu*, *akkā/akka*, or *tangai/celli* — Malayalam built its own set of sibling words. But the **structure** is identical: **four** words, not two, split by whether the sibling is **older or younger than you** —

the same signature pattern you’ve now seen across all four Dravidian languages, even where the specific words diverge.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “acchan, amma” — father, mother
- “cēṭṭan, aniyān” — older/younger brother
- “cēcci, aniyatti” — older/younger sister

Before you move on

Do Malayalam’s sibling words closely match Tamil’s? (**No** — Malayalam built its own distinct set (cēṭṭan, aniyān, cēcci, and aniyatti), unlike how closely Kannada and Telugu track Tamil.) Does Malayalam still split siblings by age? (**Yes** — four words, older vs. younger, the same structural pattern across the whole Dravidian family.)

Chapter 13

Head and Hand

13.1 തല, കൈ — head and hand, matching Tamil closely

Malayalam’s family words (*achan*, *cēṭṭan...*) went their own way from Tamil’s. Body parts snap right back to the close match you saw in colors and days.

What to know first

- തല (*thala*) = “**head**” — matches Tamil *talai* closely.
- കൈ (*kai*) = “**hand**” — matches Tamil *kai* almost exactly.

Both native Dravidian, both close cousins of Tamil’s own words — a reminder that Malayalam and Tamil’s vocabulary agreement varies concept by concept, not uniformly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “thala” — head
- “kai” — hand
- the match — nearly identical to Tamil’s *talai/kai*

Before you move on

What are Malayalam's words for head and hand, and how closely do they match Tamil? (തല **thala**, കൈ **kai** — very closely, both native Dravidian.)

Chapter 14

Seasons

14.1 വസന്തകാലം, വേനൽ, മഴ, ശൈത്യം — the same pattern as Tamil

Malayalam’s season words follow the very same recipe as Tamil’s — native words for what a season *feels like*, plus one shared Sanskrit loan for spring.

What to know first

Malayalam	meaning	source
വസന്തകാലം (<i>vasanthakaalam</i>)	“spring”	<i>vasantham</i> — the same Sanskrit loan as Tamil
വേനൽക്കാലം (<i>venalkkaalam</i>)	“summer”	വേനൽ <i>venal</i> , native Dravidian, matching Tamil <i>kodai</i> ’s role
മഴക്കാലം (<i>mazhakaalam</i>)	“rainy season”	മഴ <i>mazha</i> , native Dravidian, matching Tamil <i>mazhai</i> closely
ശൈത്യകാലം (<i>śaithyakaalam</i>)	“winter/cold season”	<i>śaithya</i> — this one leans more Sanskrit-flavored than Tamil’s native <i>kulir</i>

Every one shares the ending **-കാലം** (*-kaalam*, “time/season”) — itself ultimately from Sanskrit काल (*kāla*), but assimilated so long ago that it functions as ordinary vocabulary, quite unlike a fresher loan like *vasantham*.

Why it's said this way

As with Tamil, Kerala's actual climate is shaped far more by മഴക്കാലം (*mazhakkaalam*, “the rains” — including Kerala's famous southwest monsoon) than by a clean four-way Western split. The rains aren't a footnote to “summer” or “autumn” — they're their own major season, central to daily and agricultural life.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “venal” — summer heat — then “kaalam,” season
- “mazhakkaalam” — the rains, the real central season
- “śaithyakaalam” — the cold season
- the shared loanword — “vasanthakaalam,” spring, same as Tamil

Before you move on

Which Malayalam season-words match Tamil's closely, and which is shared with Tamil as a Sanskrit loan? (**Venal/mazha** match Tamil's *kodai/mazhai*; **vasanthakaalam** is the same Sanskrit loan as Tamil's *vasantha kaalam*.) What's the real central season in Kerala's climate? (**Mazhakkaalam**, the rains/monsoon.)

Chapter 15

Water and Rice

15.1 വെള്ളം, അരി, ചോറ് — a different water-word, the same rice-words

For once, Malayalam’s everyday word for something basic genuinely **doesn’t** match Tamil’s — even though water is about as basic as vocabulary gets.

What to know first

വെള്ളം (*vellam*) = “**water**” — and notably, this is **not** built on *n̄r* the way Tamil’s *taṇṇ̄r* is. Instead, *vellam* shares the വെൾ (*vel-*, “**bright, white**”) root you already met in *velli*, “silver/ Venus,” from the colors and days lessons — *vellam* originally meant something closer to “**flood, deluge**” before becoming Malayalam’s plain, everyday word for water. (*N̄r* itself hasn’t vanished from Malayalam — it survives inside compounds like ഇളനീർ *iḷan̄r*, “tender coconut water,” and കണ്ണീർ *kaṇṇ̄r*, “tears” — it’s just not the standalone everyday word anymore.)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Rice, though, tells the familiar story:

- അരി (*ari*) = “**rice**” (raw grain) — closely matching Tamil *arisi*.
- ചോറ് (*cōru*) = “**cooked rice**” (the meal) — and here Malayalam actually **does** have a Tamil cognate: Tamil keeps its own native சோறு (also *cōru*), used alongside the Sanskrit-influenced *sātam* as an everyday near-synonym. Malayalam simply made *cōru* its main word, where Tamil more

often reaches for *sātam*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vellaṁ” — water, NOT matching Tamil’s *neer*
- “ari” — raw rice, matching Tamil closely
- “cōru” — cooked rice, Malayalam’s own word

Before you move on

Does Malayalam’s everyday water-word match Tamil’s? (**No** — *vellaṁ* shares the *vel-* “bright/white” root instead, originally meaning “flood”; though *nīr* itself survives in compounds like *iḷanīr* and *kaṇṇīr*.) Does its raw-rice word match Tamil’s? (**Yes** — *ari* closely matches *arisi*.)

Chapter 16

The Traditional Months

16.1 ചിങ്ങം to കർക്കടകം — Kerala’s own solar calendar, named by the zodiac

Malayalam, like Tamil, has its **own** solar calendar — but even here, the two closest cousins name their months by two **different** logics.

What to know first

ചിങ്ങം, കന്നി, തുലാം, വൃശ്ചികം, ധനു, മകരം, കുമാരം, മീനം, മേടം, ഇടവം, മിഥുനം, കർക്കടകം (*Chinṇam, Kanni, Tulām, Vṛścikam, Dhanu, Makaram, Kumbham, Mīnam, Mēḍam, Iḍavam, Mithunam, Karkīḍakam*).

This is the **Kollam Era** calendar (also called the Malayalam calendar), Kerala’s own solar civil calendar — genuinely separate from the Gregorian, the pan-Indian Hindu lunisolar calendar, **and** Tamil’s solar calendar.

Why it’s said this way

Both Tamil’s and Malayalam’s calendars are **solar**, and both are independent of the Hindu lunisolar system — but they name their months differently. Tamil ties each month to a **nakshatra** (a lunar-mansion star cluster). Malayalam instead names each month directly for the **zodiac sign** (*rāśi*) the sun is passing through: ചിങ്ങം (*Chinṇam*) = Leo, കന്നി (*Kanni*) = Virgo, തുലാം (*Tulām*) = Libra, and so on straight through the zodiac. Same underlying idea — track the sun’s yearly path against the stars — but two Dravidian languages chose two different sets of star-markers to name it by.

ചിങ്ങം 1 (the 1st of Chinṇam) marks the **Malayalam New Year** and

the start of the **Onam** festival season — Kerala’s own solar calendar, running its own independent year.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “Chiñṇam, Kanni, Tulām, Vṛścikam, Dhanu, Makaram, Kumbham, Mīnam, Mēḍam, Iḍavam, Mithunam, Karkīḍakam”
- “Chiñṇam = Leo” — a zodiac sign, not a nakshatra
- the contrast — Tamil uses nakshatras, Malayalam uses zodiac signs

Before you move on

Is Malayalam’s calendar solar or lunisolar? (**Solar** — like Tamil’s, and separate from the Hindu lunisolar system.) How does it differ from Tamil’s in naming logic? (**Zodiac signs** — Chiñṇam=Leo, Kanni=Virgo — rather than Tamil’s nakshatra-based names.) What does Chiñṇam 1 mark? (**Malayalam New Year**, the start of the Onam season.)

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

17.1 ഉച്ച — a different Sanskrit metaphor, not a Sanskrit-free one

Kannada and Telugu both reached for Sanskrit’s *madhya*, “middle,” to name noon. Malayalam looks different at first glance — but be careful before you call it “native.”

What to know first

ഉച്ച (*ucha*) = “**noon, midday**” — and unlike Kannada’s *madhyāhna* or Telugu’s *madhyāhnam*, this is **not** a *madhya* (“middle”) compound at all. It most likely shares its root with Tamil உச்சி (*ucci*, “**crown of the head, peak, summit, zenith**”) and Kannada’s own ಉಚ್ಚಿ (*ucci*). Here’s the honest twist: per Wiktionary, that whole *ucci* family across Tamil and Kannada is itself documented as a **Sanskrit borrowing**, from उच्च (*ucca*, “**high**”). Malayalam’s own *ucha* has no fully documented etymology yet, so treat the connection as likely rather than settled — but if it holds, this isn’t a case of Malayalam **avoiding** Sanskrit at all. It’s Malayalam reaching for a **different** Sanskrit root than its neighbors: *ucca* (“high”) instead of *madhya* (“middle”). Noon becomes “**the sun at its peak**” rather than “the middle of the day” — the same zenith-based idea you already saw in Arabic’s *az-ẓuhr* (from a root meaning “to appear, become visible/apex”), just arrived at from Sanskrit rather than Arabic.

Why it’s said this way

Don’t walk away thinking Malayalam dodged Sanskrit here while Kannada and Telugu didn’t. The more likely picture: ഉച്ച may be just as

Sanskrit-rooted as *madhyāhna* — it’s simply a *different* Sanskrit root (*ucca*, “high,” rather than *madhya*, “middle”). What’s genuinely different is the **metaphor**, not necessarily the **language of origin**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ucha” — noon, “the peak” — compare Tamil’s “ucci”
- the honest contrast — Kannada/Telugu’s noon word means “middle”; Malayalam’s most likely means “peak” — both probably still Sanskrit, just different Sanskrit roots

Before you move on

Is ഉച്ച a Sanskrit “middle” word like Kannada’s *madhyāhna*? (**No** — it most likely comes from a *different* Sanskrit root, *ucca*, “high/peak,” not *madhya*, “middle.”) Does that make ഉച്ച a native Dravidian word? (**Not necessarily** — its likely relatives, Tamil *ucci* and Kannada *ucci*, are themselves documented Sanskrit borrowings.)

17.2 പാതിരാ — midnight as “half-night”

ഉച്ച named noon by the sun’s height. Malayalam builds midnight with a different spatial idea: cut the night in half.

What to know first

പാതിരാ (*paathira*) means “**midnight**.” It is built on പാതി (*paathi*), the everyday Malayalam word for “**half**”—as in *paathi vila*, “half price”—fused with a shortened form of “night.”

The result has the same “half-night” shape as Telugu అర్ధరాత్రి (*ardharātri*) and Hindi *ādhī rāt*. The pieces are not all cousins, though. Malayalam പാതി is a genuinely different word from Sanskrit **ardha**, the root behind Telugu *ardharātri* and, farther back, Hindi *ādhī*.

So two languages can independently choose the same transparent construction while filling it with unrelated words for “half.” The metaphor matches; the vocabulary does not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *paathira* — midnight
- *paathi* — half
- Malayalam *paathi* versus Sanskrit *ardha* — same job, different roots

Before you move on

What does പാതിരാ build on? (പാതി, “half,” plus a shortened night-word.) Is *paathi* the same root as Telugu *ardha*? (**No.** The two languages share the “half-night” logic but use unrelated half-words.)

Chapter 18

Telling Time

18.1 മണി — one word in Malayalam’s dictionaries, two in Tamil’s

Kannada and Telugu both borrowed Sanskrit’s “bell” word for “hour.” Malayalam’s story is genuinely murkier — and it’s about to disagree with its closest cousin, Tamil, on how this exact word is even structured.

What to know first

മണി (*mani*) = “hour, o’clock” — and it also means “bell, gong” and “gem, jewel, pearl.” Here’s the honest, slightly untidy part: Malayalam’s own dictionary tradition treats **all three of these senses as ONE word**, borrowed from Sanskrit मणि (*maṇi*, “gem, jewel, pearl”) — the same Sanskrit word behind names like *Manipravalam* and the mantra syllable in “*om mani padme hum*.” Under this account, “bell/hour” isn’t a separate native word at all — it’s just another meaning that grew out of the same borrowed “gem” word (a bell-shaped gem or ornament, perhaps, extending to the bell itself, and then to the hour it announces).

Why it’s said this way

Here’s what makes this genuinely interesting rather than settled: Tamil’s closely related cognate மணி is analyzed very differently by Tamil’s own reference dictionaries — as **two separate, unrelated words** that happen to be spelled and pronounced identically: a **native Dravidian** “bell, gong” word (which extends to “hour”), and a completely separate Sanskrit loan meaning “gem.” The broader comparative Dravidian

dictionary (DEDR) does list Malayalam among the languages sharing that native “bell” word too — but even DEDR flags a possible Sanskrit connection for the whole word-family as unresolved. So: two closest-cousin languages, and even the specialists don’t fully agree on whether this is one Sanskrit word wearing three meanings, or a native word and a Sanskrit word that just happen to sound alike.

Grammar Lens: telling the time

ഒരു മണി. — “One o’clock.” (*oru mani*, “one hour/bell”)
 രണ്ട് മണി. — “Two o’clock.” (*raṇṭṭu mani*, “two hour/bell”)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mani” — hour, also “bell,” also “gem” — genuinely debated whether that’s one word or two
- “oru mani” — one o’clock
- the honest point — Malayalam’s own dictionaries call it one Sanskrit word; Tamil’s call the bell/hour sense a separate, native word

Before you move on

According to Malayalam’s own dictionary tradition, are “hour,” “bell,” and “gem” one word or two? (**One** — all traced to Sanskrit *maṇi*, “gem.”) How does Tamil’s own dictionary tradition treat its cognate word differently? (As **two separate, unrelated homophones** — a native “bell/hour” word and a distinct Sanskrit “gem” loan.) Is this fully settled? (**No** — even the comparative Dravidian dictionary flags the Sanskrit connection as an open question.)

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

19.1 നിങ്ങൾക്ക് എത്ര വയസ്സുണ്ട്? — “to you, how much age exists?”

Same Sanskrit word as Kannada and Telugu — but Malayalam builds a genuinely different sentence around it.

What to know first

വയസ്സ് (*vayass*) = “age” — the same Sanskrit वयस् (*vayas*, “age, vigor,” PIE cousin of Latin *vīs*) behind Kannada’s *vayassu* and Telugu’s *vayasu*.

Grammar Lens: dative subject + “exists”

നിങ്ങൾക്ക് എത്ര വയസ്സുണ്ട്? — “How old are you?” (formal/plural) — literally “**to you, how much age exists?**” (*ningalkku ethra vayassuntū?* — from *ningalkku*, “to you” [dative] + *ethra vayassu*, “how much age” + *untū*, “exists.”) എനിക്ക് ഇരുപത് വയസ്സുണ്ട്. — “I am twenty years old.” — literally “**to me twenty age exists.**” (*enikku irupatu vayassuntū.*)

This is a real grammatical departure from Kannada and Telugu’s plain “your age how-much?” Malayalam puts the **person in the dative case** (“to you,” not “your”) and adds ഉണ്ട് (*untū*, “exists, there is”) — the same existential verb Malayalam uses for ordinary possession and existence sentences generally. So the literal shape is “**to me, twenty years’ worth of age exists**” — a dative-subject-plus-existential-verb construction, genuinely different from its two Dravidian cousins even

though the age-word itself is identical.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vayassu” — age
- “ningalkku ethra vayassuntũ?” — how old are you?
- “enikku irupatu vayassuntũ” — I am twenty, “to me twenty age exists”

Before you move on

Is Malayalam’s വയസ്സ് the same Sanskrit word as Kannada’s and Telugu’s? (**Yes.**) Does Malayalam ask age the same simple way Kannada and Telugu do? (**No** — it uses a **dative** subject, “to you,” plus the existential verb ഉണ്ട്, “exists.”) What does *enikku irupatu vayassuntũ* literally mean? (“**To me twenty age exists.**”)

Chapter 20

Numbers 11–20 and Weather

20.1 പതിനൊന്ന്, ഇരുപത് — transparent “two-tens,” matching Tamil closely

Malayalam keeps the same “two-tens” idea you’ve now seen across this whole family — and here it’s still fully visible on the surface, almost identically to its closest cousin, Tamil.

What to know first

Malayalam’s teens echo പത്ത് (*pathu*, “ten”) plus each digit. പതിനൊന്ന് (*pathinonnu*) is 11, പന്ത്രണ്ട് (*panthraṇṭṭ*) is 12, and the pattern continues through പത്തൊമ്പത് (*pathompathu*, 19) — the same digit-plus-ten-echo compounding as its Dravidian cousins.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഇരുപത് (*irupathu*, “twenty”) = ഇരു (*iru*, an older word for “two”) + പത്ത് (*pathu*, “ten”) — still fully visible as “two-tens” today. This matches **Tamil’s own** *irupathu* almost letter-for-letter, both languages having kept this compound transparent — unlike Telugu’s *iravai*, which most likely continues the same underlying pattern but has worn down past the point of visibly splitting apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pathinonnu, panthraṇṭṭ” — 11, 12

- “iru” — an older word for two, “pathu” — ten
- “irupathu” — twenty, “two-tens,” transparent

Before you move on

How are Malayalam’s teens built? (പത്ത് (ten) + a digit, compounded.) What two pieces build ഇരുപത് (twenty)? (ഇരു “two” + പത്ത് “ten” — “two-tens.”) Which other Dravidian language keeps this exact same transparent compound for twenty? (**Tamil**.)

20.2 കാലാവസ്ഥ — “the state of time,” an echo of Spanish’s tiempo

Remember Spanish’s *tiempo*, one word for both “time” and “weather”? Malayalam reaches the same connection between time and weather — but builds it as a compound instead of reusing one word.

What to know first

കാലാവസ്ഥ (*kālāvastha*) = “weather” — built from:

- കാലം (*kālam*, “time”) — Sanskrit काल (*kāla*), “time,” also the name of the god **Kāla** (an epithet of Śiva/Yama as the personification of time).
- അവസ്ഥ (*avastha*, “state, condition”) — Sanskrit अवस्था (*avasthā*).

So *kālāvastha* literally means “the state of time” — a genuinely different construction than Spanish’s *tiempo*, but reaching for the exact same underlying idea: weather as bound up with time. Where Spanish just **reuses** its word for “time” to also mean “weather,” Malayalam **compounds** “time” with “state” to build a brand-new word for the same concept.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

മഴ പെയ്യുന്നു. — “It’s raining.” — literally “rain is falling.” (*mazha peyyunnu*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kālāvastha” — weather, “the state of time”
- “kālam” — time, “avastha” — state
- “mazha peyyunnu” — it’s raining, “rain is falling”

Before you move on

What are the two Sanskrit pieces of കാലാവസ്ഥ, and what does the whole word literally mean? (കാലം, “time,” + അവസ്ഥ, “state” — “**the state of time.**”) What earlier lesson does this echo, and how is the construction different? (Spanish’s *tiempo* — Spanish reuses ONE word for both senses; Malayalam **compounds** two separate words instead.) What word does Malayalam use for “rain”? (മഴ, *mazha*.)

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

21.1 നായ, പൂച്ച — matching Tamil closely on both counts

Malayalam keeps close company with its nearest cousin, Tamil, on both words this time — while still fitting into the honest, more fragmented Dravidian picture for “cat.”

What to know first

നായ (*nāya*, “dog”) continues the same solid, native **Proto-Dravidian** root as Kannada’s ನಾಯಿ (*nāyi*) and Tamil’s own word — no mystery here at all, unlike every dog-word you’ve met elsewhere in this entire arc.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പൂച്ച (*pūcha*, “cat”) closely matches Tamil’s **everyday** word for cat — a different root from Kannada’s ಬೆಕ್ಕು (*bekku*, related instead to the word for “wildcat”) and Telugu’s పిల్లి (*pilli*, a separate Proto-Dravidian root of its own, most likely the source behind Sanskrit’s *biḍāla* and Hindi’s *billī*). So “cat” genuinely splits three ways across just these four Dravidian languages, even though “dog” mostly agrees.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāya” — dog, same solid root as Kannada and Tamil
- “pūcha” — cat, matching Tamil’s everyday word closely

Before you move on

Does നായ share Kannada's *nāyi* root? (**Yes** — the same solid, native Proto-Dravidian root.) Does పిల్లి match Kannada's *bekku* or Tamil's everyday cat-word? (**Tamil's** — Kannada's *bekku* and Telugu's *pilli* both come from different roots entirely.)

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

22.1 പച്ച, മഞ്ഞ — matching Tamil twice over, by two different routes

Telugu’s green and yellow turned out to be one word wearing two faces. Malayalam’s green and yellow are a different story again — two completely separate native words, each one matching Tamil closely, just not matching *each other*.

What to know first

പച്ച (*paccha*, “green”) comes from **Proto-Dravidian** **pac-* — matching **Tamil**’s பச்சை (*paccai*) almost exactly, and the same root already seen in Kannada’s *hasiru* and Telugu’s *pacca*. No surprises here; this is the familiar family from the last two lessons.

Why it’s said this way

മഞ്ഞ (*mañña*, “yellow”) and മഞ്ഞൾ (*maññal*, “turmeric”) are a native **doublet pair**. This is a **completely different** Dravidian root from *pac-*, matching **Tamil**’s own turmeric/yellow pair, மஞ்சள் (*mañ-cal*), closely. So here’s the honest shape of this arc so far: Kannada split green and yellow into two unrelated families (native vs. Sanskrit loan); Telugu kept them as doublets of the **same** native root; and Malayalam keeps them as **two separate** native Dravidian roots, each one independently matching its Tamil counterpart. No single pattern holds across all three languages — the honest answer is that each solved “green vs. yellow” its own way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “പച്ച” — green, matching Tamil *paccai*
- “മഞ്ഞ” — yellow, matching Tamil *mañcaḷ*, a separate root entirely
- the contrast — *paccha* and *mañña* are NOT doublets of each other, unlike Telugu’s *pacca/pasupu*

Before you move on

Does മഞ്ഞ (*mañña*, “yellow”) share a root with പച്ച (*paccha*, “green”)? (**No** — they are two separate native Dravidian roots.) What Tamil word does മഞ്ഞ closely match? (மஞ்சள், *mañcaḷ*, “turmeric/yellow.”) Across Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam, is there one single pattern for how green and yellow relate? (**No** — Kannada split them into native vs. Sanskrit-loan; Telugu made them doublets of one root; Malayalam keeps them as two separate native roots.)

Chapter 23

Day

23.1 ദിവസം (divasam) — the everyday Sanskrit day-word

You already met Malayalam’s native word for “day” back in Chapter 4 — hiding inside “tomorrow.” This lesson gives it, and its Sanskrit rival, their own honest reckoning.

What to know first

ദിവസം (divasam) — “day” — is Malayalam’s common, everyday word for counting a day (as in മൂന്ന് ദിവസം, *mūnnu divasam*, “three days”). It’s a Sanskrit **tatsama**, borrowed whole from दिवस (*divasa*), which itself traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **dyew-* (“to shine”), via the Sanskrit root दिव् (*div*). That’s the **same ultimate PIE root** behind Hindi/Kannada’s दिन/ದಿನ (*dina*) and Latin’s own *diēs* — but be careful here: *divasa* and *dina* are **two different Sanskrit formations** off that shared root (one built with an *-asa* suffix, one with Sanskrit’s own *-nó-* formation), not the same word wearing two scripts. Same root, different branch — the *din/diēs* pattern, replaying itself one level deeper, inside Sanskrit.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Malayalam also has ദിനം (*dinam*) — the **exact same** Sanskrit tatsama word as Kannada’s plain, everyday *dina*. But in Malayalam, **dinam** is the more **literary, formal** alternate (think ജന്മദിനം, *janmadinam*, “birthday,” the modern calque-style term) — **divasam** does the everyday counting work instead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “divasam” — “day,” the everyday counting word
- “dinam” — the same Sanskrit word as Kannada’s *dina*, but formal here

Before you move on

What PIE root does ദിവസം ultimately share with Hindi/Kannada’s *dina* and Latin’s *diēs*? (**dyew-*, “to shine” — though *divasa* and *dina* are different Sanskrit formations off it, not the same word.) Which is the everyday counting word? (**divasam**.) Which is more literary or formal? (**dinam**.)

23.2 നാൾ — the native day-word that narrowed its job

ദിവസം counts ordinary days and ദിനം writes formally. But Malayalam’s native day-word never disappeared—you met it long ago inside “tomorrow.”

What to know first

നാൾ (*nāl*) means “day” and descends from Proto-Dravidian **nāl*, cognate with Tamil நாள் and Kannada ನಾಳ. Chapter 4 already gave you നാളെ (*nāle*, “tomorrow”), with the native day-word still visible inside.

The Sanskrit loan ദിവസം took over ordinary counting, but നാൾ narrowed rather than vanished. ഒരു നാൾ (*oru nāl*, “one day”) remains natural in storytelling, and the word stays productive in പിറന്നാൾ (*pirannāl*), “birthday,” literally “day of birth.” That traditional compound stands beside the newer Sanskrit-style ജന്മദിനം (*janmadinam*).

Three words therefore carry three honest jobs: *divasam* counts, *dinam* is formal, and native *nāl* tells stories and marks birthdays. This echoes Kannada’s native *hagalu*: borrowing narrowed a native word’s domain without erasing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nāḷe* — tomorrow, with *nāḷ* inside
- *oru nāḷ* — one day, narrative register
- *pirannāḷ* — birthday, day of birth

Before you move on

Has Sanskrit **divasam** erased native നാൾ? (**No.**) Where does *nāḷ* live now? (**Inside tomorrow, in narrative “one day,” and in the living compound for birthday.**)

Chapter 24

Night

24.1 രാത്രി (rāthri) — night, already hiding inside midnight

Last lesson’s *divasam* had three words doing three honest jobs. This word’s family is smaller, but the split is just as real — and one piece of it, you’ve technically already heard.

What to know first

രാത്രി (rāthri) — “**night**” — is a Sanskrit **tatsama**. You’ve likely already met a piece of it: പാതിരാ (pāthirā, “midnight,” Chapter 17) is built from പാതി (pāthi, “half”) fused with what’s most plausibly a **shortened form** of this very word — “**rā**” standing in for the whole of *rāthri* (Chapter 17 itself didn’t spell out which word was being shortened, but the parallel Tamil compound, *pāti-y-irāttiri*, points the same way). This lesson gives it its own, full standing.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest echo from earlier in this arc: just like Hindi’s own रात (*raat*, ultimately from the same Sanskrit रात्रि), Malayalam’s *rāthri* traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **h₁reh₁-* (“to rest”) — a **completely different** PIE root from Latin’s *nox* (**nók^wts*). Two Indo-European languages, two words for “night,” that **look** like they might be old cousins — but genuinely **aren’t**. Same false-cognate story, now confirmed across a second Indo-Aryan-rooted borrowing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rāthri” — “night,” already hiding, shortened, inside pāthirā
- the honest PIE echo — h_1reh_1 -, “to rest,” like Hindi’s *raat*, *NOT* related to Latin’s *nox*

Before you move on

Where did you already, technically, meet a piece of രാത്രി before this lesson? (Shortened to “rā” inside പാതിരാ, *pāthirā*, “midnight,” Chapter 17.) Does *rāthri*’s PIE root match Latin *nox*’s? (**No** — $*h_1reh_1$ - “to rest,” a completely different root, the same false-cognate pattern already seen with Hindi’s *raat*.)

24.2 ഇരവ് / ഇരുൾ — two native words, two jobs

രാത്രി is the ordinary Sanskrit night-word. Malayalam also kept two native Dravidian words, but they do not compete with it in the same way.

What to know first

- ഇരവ് (*iravū*) is cognate with Tamil இரவு (*iravu*) and is traced by one source to Proto-Dravidian $*cira$, “darkness.” It survives mainly as a **literary or classical-register** synonym for “night.” Poetry is a more likely home for it than everyday conversation.
- ഇരുൾ (*irul*) descends from Proto-Dravidian $*cirV!$ and belongs to the pan-Dravidian family Kannada ಇರುಳು, Tamil இருள், and Telugu ఇరులు. It remains current in modern Malayalam—a 2021 film is titled *Irul*—but its ordinary sense is **darkness**, not night as a time period.

This is not one native night-word simply pushed into archaism. It is two native words carrying different pieces of രാത്രി’s semantic space: one formal and poetic, the other common but narrower.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *iravũ* — literary night
- *irul* — current darkness
- related ideas, different modern jobs

Before you move on

Are ഇരവ് and ഇരുൾ interchangeable everyday words for night? (**No.**) Which is literary “night”? (**iravũ.**) Which is current “darkness”? (**irul.**)

Chapter 25

Good Night

25.1 ശുഭ രാത്രി (śubha rāthri) — “good night,” and a pattern seen before

You already have *rāthri*. One more Sanskrit word, already familiar from three earlier languages in this arc, completes Malayalam’s “good night” — and this lesson’s honest twist is one you’ve technically seen before, just in a different language.

What to know first

ശുഭ രാത്രി (śubha rāthri) — “good night” — literally “**auspicious night**.” Both pieces are Sanskrit **tatsama**: രാത്രി (*rāthri*, “night,” already met last lesson) plus ശുഭ (*śubha*, “**auspicious**,” from root śubh, “to be beautiful,” ultimately PIE **kewbʰ-* — the same word, the same root, already verified for the Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu siblings of this exact arc).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here’s the honest twist, hedged deliberately: some sources describe modern Malayalam speakers, especially in casual settings, **code-switching to English** “good night” rather than saying ശുഭ രാത്രി aloud — treating it more as the standard, correct-but-formal translation than an everyday spoken phrase. But this lesson isn’t presenting that as a fresh Malayalam discovery. The **exact same claim**, sourced from similarly thin blogs and forum posts, was already made for **Telugu** earlier in this arc — and there, it was left genuinely **unclear** whether the pattern was Telugu-specific or something broader. Seeing the same claim turn

up again for Malayalam **strengthens the suspicion that this is a broader South Asian pattern** (or simply a sourcing artifact — the languages that happen to get commented on in casual sources), not a language-specific trait worth treating as a genuine discovery each time. Either way, *śubha rāthri* itself remains perfectly correct, understood Malayalam.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha rāthri” — “good night,” literally “auspicious night”
- śubha’s own root — śubh, “to be beautiful” → “auspicious” — the same root already met for Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu
- the honest twist — this code-switching claim isn’t uniquely Malayalam’s; the same weakly-sourced claim already appeared for Telugu

Before you move on

What does ശുഭ രാത്രി literally mean? (“**Auspicious night.**”) Is the “Malayalam speakers code-switch to English instead” claim a fresh discovery in this lesson? (**No** — the identical claim, similarly thinly sourced, already appeared for **Telugu** earlier in this arc, suggesting a broader pattern or a sourcing artifact, not a Malayalam-specific fact.) Does this affect whether *śubha rāthri* itself is correct? (**No** — it’s perfectly correct and understood Malayalam, whatever its actual spoken frequency.)

Chapter 26

Morning

26.1 ರಾವಿಲ (rāvile) — “morning,” built from “night”

Kannada’s morning word means “the shining.” Telugu’s means “rise.” Malayalam’s most common morning word means something stranger on its face: night.

What to know first

ರಾವಿಲ (rāvile) — “**morning**” — is, per Wiktionary, a compound: ರಾವ್ (rāvũ) plus the suffixes **-il** and **-e**. Here’s the honest surprise: ರಾವ್ shares its root — not its exact form — with the word already met in Chapter 24, ಇರಾವ್ (iravũ), there a **literary-register synonym for “night”** itself. Wiktionary confirms both as cognates, both tracing to **Proto-Dravidian *cira** (“**darkness**”) — a cognate doublet within Malayalam, not literally one word in two spellings. So Malayalam’s everyday word for “morning” is, transparently, built from **night** plus locative-ish suffixes — not from light, dawn, or rising, the strategies Kannada’s ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ (“the shining”) and Telugu’s ఉదಯం (Sanskrit “rise”) both reach for instead.

Why it’s said this way

No source spells out **why** “at/in the night” came to mean “morning” specifically — it’s a plausible semantic path (perhaps “the night just ending,” the pre-dawn hours) rather than one directly documented step by step. Treat the **morphological composition** as confirmed (Wiktionary is explicit about the rāvũ+il+e breakdown); treat the **semantic mechanism** as a reasonable but unconfirmed inference, not a settled

fact.

Why it's said this way

Malayalam keeps two other words for “morning” too. പ്രഭാതം (*prabhā-tani*) is a Sanskrit **tatsama** sharing its root — **prabhāta**, “to shine, become bright” — with Telugu’s own సుప్రభాతం (*suprabhātam*, TE-C29, this very arc’s Telugu morning-greeting word) — a genuine cross-language callback within this project. പുലർച്ച (pularcca) is native Dravidian, but be honest about its etymology: one database entry links it to a root meaning “to subsist, live,” which may or may not be the same root behind its “dawn” sense — treat that specific connection as unconfirmed, not settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rāvile” — “morning,” built from rāvũ (“night”) + locative suffixes
- the honest surprise — a cognate doublet of the night-word already met as iravũ (Chapter 24), same root, now doing morning’s job
- prabhātani — same Sanskrit root as Telugu’s suprabhātam

Before you move on

What is രാവിലെ literally built from? (രാവ് — “night” — plus locative suffixes -il/-e; a cognate doublet, same root, as ഇരവ് met in Chapter 24 — not literally the same word.) Is the exact reason “night” came to mean “morning” fully documented? (**No** — the compound itself is confirmed, but the semantic shift is a plausible, unconfirmed inference.) What root does പ്രഭാതം share with a word from Telugu’s arc? (**prabhāta** — the same root behind Telugu’s సుప్రభాతం, TE-C29.)

Chapter 27

Evening

27.1 വൈകുന്നേരം (vaikunnēram) — “evening,” built from a verb meaning “to get late”

Telugu reached for Sanskrit to name the evening. Malayalam’s most common word takes a completely different route — an everyday verb, not a borrowed noun.

What to know first

വൈകുന്നേരം (vaikunnēram) — “evening” — is, per Wiktionary, a compound: വൈക് (*vaikū*) + -ഉം (-*um*) + നേരം (*nēram*, “time”), literally “latening time.” നേരം is itself confirmed native **Proto-Dravidian** (cognate Tamil நேரம்), not a Sanskrit borrowing — so unlike Telugu’s Sanskrit సాయంత్రం, this whole compound is native Dravidian, start to finish. The വൈക് root plausibly connects to an everyday Malayalam verb, വൈകുക (*vaikuka*), confirmed “to get late” — though be honest that this specific link is the author’s own reasonable inference, not something Wiktionary’s compound entry states outright.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s a real tension, not smoothed over: Wiktionary’s own entry lists **both** “afternoon” **and** “evening” as senses of this single word. But two independently-fetched phrasebook sources (ling-app.com, talkpal.ai) draw a cleaner line — **evening** is വൈകുന്നേരം, while **afternoon** gets its own, separate compound built on ഉച്ച (already met, Chapter 17, “noon”) plus കഴിഞ്ഞ് (*kazhinju*, “passed, gone by”). This project’s discipline is to flag genuine disagreement rather than quietly pick whichever

source is more convenient — so treat the afternoon/evening boundary here as **genuinely blurry** in the dictionary sense, even though the two everyday phrasebook sources agree on a cleaner practical split.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vaikunnēram” — “evening,” literally “latening time”
- the everyday verb root — vaikuka, “to get late”
- the honest tension — Wiktionary blurs afternoon/evening; phrasebooks split them cleanly

Before you move on

What does വൈകുന്നേരം literally mean, and what verb is it plausibly built from? (“**Latening time**” — from വൈകുക, “to get late.”) Do all sources agree on where “afternoon” ends and “evening” begins for this word? (**No** — Wiktionary lists it as covering both senses; phrasebook sources instead draw a clean line, treating afternoon as a separate compound.) Is വൈകുന്നേരം a Sanskrit borrowing, like Telugu’s సాయంత్రం? (**No** — it’s a native Dravidian compound, built from an everyday verb and a native “time” word, നേരം.)

Chapter 28

Afternoon

28.1 ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ (uchakaliññ) — “noon, having passed”

Telugu let its noon-word quietly widen to also mean “afternoon.”
Malayalam solves the same problem with a completely different strategy: it builds a new phrase instead.

What to know first

ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ (uchakaliññ) — “afternoon” — is a transparent **two-word phrase**, not a single dictionary headword (no Wiktionary entry exists for the compound as a whole). It’s built from ഉച്ച (already met, Chapter 17, “noon”) plus കഴിഞ്ഞ, the **past converb form** of കഴിയുക (*kaliyuka*), itself Wiktionary-confirmed **Proto-Dravidian** **kazi* (“to be over, spent, finished”). Be honest about the citation: Wiktionary’s own conjugation line shows only the finite past tense, കഴിഞ്ഞു (*kaliññu*) — not this converb form directly. The converb is the grammatically correct choice for chaining into a compound like this one, but treat the exact written form as a reasonable grammatical inference, not a directly Wiktionary-sourced citation. Put together: “**noon having passed**” — afternoon is, quite literally, the time after noon is done.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest structural contrast: Telugu’s own afternoon word (TE-C28, మధ్యాహ్నం) is the exact **same word** as its “noon,” simply **widened** to also cover “afternoon” — one word, stretched. Malayalam does something structurally different: ഉച്ച itself stays put, meaning only “noon,”

and a **second word** — കഴിഞ്ഞ്, “passed” — gets bolted on to build a new phrase for “afternoon.” Same problem (naming the stretch of time after noon), two genuinely different solutions: semantic widening in Telugu, compositional phrase-building in Malayalam.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “uchakaliññ” — “afternoon,” literally “noon having passed”
- the verb behind it — kaliyuka, “to be over, spent” — Proto-Dravidian *kazi*
- the honest contrast — Telugu widens the same noon-word; Malayalam builds a new phrase on top of it

Before you move on

What does ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ് literally mean? (“Noon having passed” — ഉച്ച, “noon,” plus the past tense of കഴിയുക, “to be over, spent.”) Is ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ് a single dictionary word, like ഉച്ച itself? (No — it’s a transparent two-word phrase; no Wiktionary entry exists for the compound as a whole.) How does Malayalam’s strategy for naming “afternoon” differ from Telugu’s? (**Telugu widens its existing noon-word’s meaning; Malayalam instead builds a new phrase, keeping the noon-word unchanged.**)

Chapter 29

Good Morning

29.1 സുപ്രഭാതം (suprabhātaṁ) — Malayalam’s real “good morning,” a familiar word wearing a new hat

You might expect Malayalam’s “good morning” to pair ML-C25’s “auspicious” word with ML-C26’s morning word. It doesn’t — Malayalam reaches for a completely different Sanskrit “good,” and for a word you’ve technically already half-met.

What to know first

സുപ്രഭാതം (suprabhātaṁ) — “good morning” — is Malayalam’s actual, most common morning greeting: two independently-fetched sources confirm it: one states it’s used in **both formal and informal** contexts, the second separately calls it “the most general greeting” for good morning — genuine corroboration, not a single source’s claim taken on faith. Here’s the honest surprise: it is **not** built on ശുഭ (ML-C25’s “auspicious,” the word behind Malayalam’s own “good night”) at all. Instead, it’s built from the Sanskrit **prefix su-** (“good”) fused directly onto പ്രഭാതം — already met, Chapter 26, as an alternative Malayalam word for “morning.” Two genuinely different Sanskrit “good” morphemes: ശുഭ is a standalone adjective; **su-** here is a bound prefix that only ever attaches to another word.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest cross-language twist: സുപ്രഭാതം is the **exact same Sanskrit tatsama word** as Telugu’s own సుప్రభాతం (TE-C29) — same su- prefix, same ప్రభాత/prabhāta root. But the two languages hand

it **opposite jobs**. In Malayalam, it's the **primary**, most commonly used morning greeting. In Telugu, it's only a **secondary** alternative — Telugu's primary greeting, శుభోదయం, is built on a completely different Sanskrit root (*udaya*, “rise,” not *prabhāta*). Same borrowed word, opposite roles across two closely related languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “suprabhātam” — “good morning,” su- (“good”) + prabhāta (“shine, dawn,” ML-C26)
- the honest surprise — NOT built on śubha; a different Sanskrit “good” morpheme entirely
- the cross-language inversion — Malayalam's primary greeting is Telugu's secondary alternative

Before you move on

Is സുപ്രഭാതം built on ശുഭ, ML-C25's “auspicious” word? (**No** — it's built on the Sanskrit prefix su-, a different “good” morpheme, fused onto പ്രഭാതം, ML-C26's alternative morning word.) Is സുപ്രഭാതം the primary morning greeting in both Malayalam and Telugu? (**No** — it's PRIMARY in Malayalam but only a SECONDARY alternative in Telugu, where శుభోదయం — built on a different root — is primary.) Is the “used in both formal and informal contexts” claim as shaky as Telugu's own morning-greeting claim? (**No** — it's confirmed by TWO independently-fetched sources, a genuinely stronger evidentiary footing than resting on just one.)

Chapter 30

Good Evening

30.1 ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം (śubha sāyāhnam) — “good evening,” a different evening-word than expected

You might expect this greeting to pair śubha with the evening-word you already know. It doesn’t — Malayalam reaches for a completely different word instead, one with a poetic edge.

What to know first

ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം (śubha sāyāhnam) — “good evening” — is confirmed real by a directly-fetched source, used “**from late afternoon until sunset.**” It’s built from ശുഭ (ML-C25, “auspicious”) plus സായാഹ്നം (sāyāhnam, “**evening, eventide**”). Here’s the honest surprise: this is **not** built on വൈകുണ്ഠം, the native word already met in Chapter 27, at all. സായാഹ്നം is a **completely separate** word — a Sanskrit **tatsama**, which Wiktionary’s own part-of-speech label calls “**poetic.**” That’s a real, independently-checkable signal (not an unverifiable blog claim) that this particular greeting likely leans formal or literary, even though the phrase itself is confirmed correct and genuinely used.

Why it’s said this way

സായാഹ്നം is, per a Sanskrit dictionary, a compound of साय (“**end**”) plus अह्न (“**day**”) — the same “-ahna” day-part suffix already met in words like *madhyāhna* and *aparāhna*. Following the etymology one hop further, Wiktionary’s own साय entry explicitly confirms this root traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **seh₁-* (“**long, lasting**”), directly naming

सायम् (*sāyam* — Telugu’s own TE-C27 root) and **Latin** *sērus* as cognates. So this is a genuinely, properly-verified shared ancestor with Telugu’s సాయంత్రం (TE-C27) — the same striking PIE chain to Latin *sērus*, French **soir**, and Italian **sera** — not merely a plausible guess, but a confirmed cognate, reached by chaining through two Wiktionary pages rather than stopping at the first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha sāyāhnamī” — “good evening,” confirmed real, used from late afternoon until sunset
- the honest surprise — NOT built on vaikunnēramī; a separate, Wiktionary-labeled “poetic” Sanskrit word instead
- the confirmed echo — sāyāhnamī’s साय root genuinely shares TE-C27’s PIE *seh₁*-/Latin *sērus* connection

Before you move on

Is ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം built on വൈകുണ്ഠം, ML-C27’s native evening word? (**No** — സായാഹ്നം is a completely separate Sanskrit tatsama.) What does Wiktionary’s own part-of-speech label for സായാഹ്നം suggest about its register? (“**Poetic**” — a real, checkable signal it likely skews formal or literary.) Is it confirmed that സായാഹ്നം shares TE-C27’s spectacular PIE root? (**Yes** — Wiktionary’s separate साय entry directly confirms the same PIE *seh₁*-ancestry, naming *sāyam* and Latin *sērus* as cognates — a genuinely verified shared root, reached by following the etymology one hop further.)

Chapter 31

Good Afternoon

31.1 ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം (śubha madhyāhnam) — formal good afternoon

Morning broke the pattern entirely. Evening kept the pattern but swapped in an unexpected word. This final greeting brings a different kind of surprise: a word you haven’t met, that turns out to connect Malayalam right back to Kannada and Telugu.

What to know first

ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം (śubha madhyāhnam) — “good afternoon” — is confirmed, by a directly-fetched source, as a genuinely **formal** greeting: “**mainly used in official or ceremonial settings**” and “**not as commonly used in daily conversation.**” (A suspiciously precise “fewer than 1%” statistic turned up in an initial search summary for this claim — but it couldn’t be traced to either page actually fetched, so it’s deliberately left out here as an apparent confabulation; the real, hedged qualitative finding stands on its own.) It’s built from ശുഭ (ML-C25) plus മധ്യാഹ്നം (*madhyāhnam*, “noon”) — which Wiktionary confirms is a direct **synonym** of ML-C17’s ഉച്ച. Here’s the honest surprise: Malayalam had this “middle”-based noon-word all along — ML-C17 simply didn’t highlight it, teaching ഉച്ച (“peak, high”) instead. And this greeting is **not** built on ML-C28’s ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ് compound (the actual TIME-AFTERNOON phrase already taught) at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha madhyāhnam” — “good afternoon,” a formal, ceremonial-register greeting
- the honest surprise — madhyāhnam is a genuine synonym of ucca, Malayalam’s own “noon” word, just not the one taught first

Before you move on

Is ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം built on ML-C28’s ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ? (No — it’s built on മധ്യാഹ്നം, a genuine Wiktionary-confirmed synonym of ML-C17’s ഉച്ച, not the TIME-AFTERNOON compound.) Is the “fewer than 1% use this” statistic something this lesson confirms? (No — it couldn’t be traced to any directly-fetched source and is deliberately excluded; only the hedged “formal, not common in daily conversation” finding is asserted.)

31.2 One greeting, three afternoon strategies

Malayalam’s formal greeting uses ശുഭ + മധ്യാഹ്നം. Kannada and Telugu land on the same phrase—but their ordinary afternoon words took three different routes.

What to know first

language	formal afternoon greeting
Malayalam	ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം
Kannada	ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ
Telugu	శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం

All three share the Sanskrit śubha + madhyāhna structure. That shared greeting is striking because the languages’ everyday time words diverge:

- **Telugu** widened its *madhya*-based noon-word so the same word also covers afternoon.
- **Kannada** built a separate Sanskrit tatsama, ಅಪರಾಹ್ನ (aparāhna, *apara* + *ahna*), rather than widening *madhyāhna*.
- **Malayalam** built ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ, the unrelated *ucca* “noon” plus “having passed.”

So there are three genuinely different everyday strategies, not a simple two-versus-one split. At the formal greeting layer, all three converge on the same borrowed building blocks.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the shared greeting structure — *śubha + madhyāhna*
- Telugu — widening
- Kannada — a separate *aparāhna* word
- Malayalam — “noon having passed”

Before you move on

Do the three languages share one ordinary afternoon-word strategy? **(No.)** Where do they converge? **(In the formal greeting, all using śubha + madhyāhna.)**

Chapter 32

The Core Verbs

32.1 ഉണ്ട് (uṇṭŭ) — “there is,” and the machine inside every Malayalam verb

Thirty-one chapters of words. Now the engine room. English makes one verb, “to be,” do three jobs. Malayalam uses three words.

What to know first

ഉണ്ട് — *uṇṭŭ* — there is, there are; [someone] has

ഇരിക്കുക — *irikkuka* — to be somewhere, to stay, to sit

Chapter 2 gave you ആണ് (*āṇŭ*), the “is” that links two nouns: *enre pēru Arun āṇŭ*, “my name is Arun.” ഉണ്ട് does a different job — **existing** and **having**: *enikku oru sahōdaran uṇṭŭ*, “to-me one brother there-is,” which is how Malayalam says “I have a brother.” ഇരിക്കുക is being in a **place**: *ñān vīṭṭil irikkunnu*, “I am at home.”

Identity, existence, location — and none stands in for another.

The letters in this word

ഉ (the standing vowel *u*) + ണ് + ൾ → ഉണ്ട്. Both consonants are retroflex — tongue curled back — and both have had their vowel stripped, so the word trails off on a half-swallowed *ŭ*: *uṇ-tŭ*. ഇരിക്കുക runs *i-rik-ku-ka*, with the doubled ക held long.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Both are native Dravidian, from the oldest layer, and the family split them between its daughters: **Tamil** kept இரு (*iru*), “be, stay”; **Kannada** kept the same word, ಇರು (*iru*); **Telugu** kept the other one, ఉండు (*undu*).

Malayalam kept **both**, and gave each a job.

Grammar Lens: two pieces, where Tamil has three

English changes a verb with words **around** it: *I am, I was, I will be*. Malayalam glues a piece **onto the end**:

ഇരിക്ക് + ഉന്നു → ഇരിക്കുന്നു

irikk- (stay) + *-unnu* (happening now) → *irikkunnu*

Stem, then tense. Two slots, and that is the whole machine.

Tamil glues on a **third** piece naming who acts: *iru* + *-kkir-* + *-ēn* (I) → *irukkireṇ*, “I am,” against *irukkiraṇ*, “he is.” Malayalam threw that slot away. *Ñān irikkunnu*, *nī irikkunnu*, *avan irikkunnu* — the verb never moves. Chapter 5 showed this with one verb; it holds for **every** Malayalam verb, and for no sister.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three jobs — “āṇṭṭ” is, “uṇṭṭ” there-is, “irikkuka” be somewhere
- “enikku oru sahōdaran uṇṭṭ” — I have a brother
- the two pieces — “irikk ... unnu”
- one verb, three people — “ñān, nī, avan ... irikkunnu”

Before you move on

Which be-word does Malayalam use for having something? (ഉണ്ടു, *uṇṭṭ*.) What are the two pieces of *irikkunnu*? (**Stem and tense**; there is no third piece.) How does the verb change between “I stay” and “he stays”? (**It does not.**) Next: the piece that carries time.

32.2 പോകുക (pōkuka) — “to go,” and the piece that carries time

Stem, then tense. Hold the stem still and swap the second piece.
That is the whole of Malayalam tense, and it is a shorter list than you expect.

What to know first

പോകുക — *pōkuka* — to go

Chapter 4 met this verb in passing, on the way to a farewell. Here it goes to work. The dictionary form is the stem പോക്- (*pōk-*) plus -ഉക (-*uka*), the ending that means “to ____.”

when	Malayalam	the ending
now	<i>pōkunnu</i>	<i>-unnu</i>
already	<i>pōyi</i>	<i>-i</i>
not yet	<i>pōkum</i>	<i>-um</i>

You have said the middle one already: the goodbye പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varām*) opens with *pōyi*, “having gone.”

The letters in this word

പോ (*pa* wearing the long-*ō* sign) + കു (*ku*) + ക (*ka*) → പോകുക.
The *ō* is long and round; let it run.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പോ- is native Dravidian, so old it has barely moved: Tamil പോ (*pō*), Telugu పో (*pōvu*), the same verb.

Kannada’s everyday word is ಹೋಗು (*hōgu*), and that *h* is no different root. Old Dravidian *p-* softened to *h-* in Kannada — “ten” is Malayalam പത്ത് (*pattū*) against Kannada ಹತ್ತು (*hattu*), the very same swap.

Grammar Lens: three forms are the whole conjugation

In most languages a tense is a **list**. English has *I go* / *he goes*. Tamil, Malayalam’s closest sister, needs an ending for every person: *pōgīrēn* (“I go”), *pōgīrāy* (“you go”), *pōgīrān* (“he goes”), *pōgīrōm* (“we go”). Malayalam’s present tense is one word long. *Ōn pōkunnu*, *nī pōkunnu*,

avan pōkunnu, avar pōkunnu — I, you, he, they, and *pōkunnu* every time. So those three forms are not the start of a conjugation. **They are the whole of it.**

That is the bargain. Nothing to memorise on the verb — and the pronoun in front can never be dropped, since it is now the only thing telling you who went.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pōkuka” — to go
- the three times — “pōkunnu ... pōyi ... pōkum̃”
- the pair that shares one sound-law — “pattū ... hattu”, “pō ... hōgu”
- four people, one verb — “ñān, nī, avan, avar ... pōkunnu”

Before you move on

Say “I will go.” (*Ñān pōkum̃.*) How many words are in this verb’s whole Malayalam present tense? (**One** — *pōkunnu*, for every person.) Is Kannada’s *hōgu* a different root from *pō*? (**No** — the same old *p* softened to *h*.) Next: the one place a Malayalam verb can still surprise you.

32.3 വരുക (varuka) — “to come,” and a past that reshapes the stem

Pōkuka took its endings without a fuss. Its lifelong partner does not — and the difference sits in exactly one of the three tenses.

What to know first

വരുക — *varuka* — to come

The stem is വരു- (*varu-*), and the command is shorter still: വാ! (*vā!*), “come!” (Chapter 4 met the dictionary form in its other common spelling, വരിക, *varika*; both name this verb.)

Go and come are inseparable here. The everyday goodbye പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varām*) is the two verbs holding hands — “having gone, I’ll come” — and Malayalam has no plain farewell that leaves the coming back out.

The letters in this word

വ (*va*) + രു (*ru*) + ക (*ka*) → വരുക, three light beats. In the past form വന്നു (*vannu*) the ന is a doubled *n*, held long: *van-nu*, not *vanu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Native Dravidian, and every sister kept it — each reshaping the front of the word. **Tamil** has வா (*vā*) as the command and வரு- (*varu-*) as the stem; **Kannada** has ಬಾ (*bā*); **Telugu** has రా (*rā*).

V, *b*, *r*: three regular reworkings of one old word, not three verbs. And Malayalam’s *vā* / *varu-* pairing is Tamil’s exactly, down to the two shapes — which is what “closest sister” means in practice.

Grammar Lens: where Malayalam keeps its irregularity

Line the two verbs up:

tense	go	come
now	<i>pōkunnu</i>	<i>varunnu</i>
already	<i>pōyi</i>	<i>vannu</i>
not yet	<i>pōkum</i>	<i>varum</i>

Present and future are built the same way for both: stem, plus *-unnu* or *-um*. The past is not — *varu-* collapses into *vann-*, and no rule would have told you so.

That is Malayalam’s whole irregularity budget, spent in one place. Once a verb’s **past** is learned, nothing else about it can catch you out, because the missing person slot means there is no second, third or plural form waiting behind it. A Malayalam verb costs you three forms. A Tamil one costs three tenses times six persons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the command — “vā!”
- the three times — “varunnu ... vannu ... varum”

- the pair, past against past — “pōyi ... vannu”
- the goodbye you now understand — “pōyi varāṁ”

Before you move on

Which tense of *varuka* is the irregular one? (**The past** — *vannu*.) Say “I will come.” (*Ñān varuni*.) Are Kannada *bā* and Telugu *rā* different verbs from *varuka*? (**No** — one old Dravidian word, reshaped three ways.) Next: a verb Malayalam kept where Tamil built a new one.

32.4 തിന്നുക (tinnuka) — “to eat,” and the ending that names a verb’s homeland

Malayalam took in a great deal of Sanskrit. Eating is one of the places it never reached.

What to know first

തിന്നുക — *tinnuka* — to eat

ഉണ്ണുക — *uṇṇuka* — to eat a meal, to dine

Two inherited verbs, both alive. *Tinnuka* is eating in general. *Uṇṇuka* is sitting down to a proper meal, and gives the noun ഉൺ (*uṇṇ*), “lunch.” The tenses are regular: *tinnunnu*, *tinnu*, *tinnuni*.

The letters in this word

തി (*ti*) + ന്ന (a doubled *nn* with *u*) + ക (*ka*) → തിന്നുക, with the long *n* you held in *vannu*. In ഉണ്ണുക that doubled letter is retroflex ണ് (*ṇṇ*): *uṇ-ṇu-ka*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

തിന്നുക goes back to Dravidian *tin-*, and the family kept it: Telugu తిను (*tinu*), Kannada ತಿನ್ನು (*tinnu*).

Tamil kept *tin* too, as தின், but narrowed it to chewing and built a **new** everyday word from two of its own: சாப்பிடு (*sāppidu*) is *sāppu* (“food”) plus *idu* (“to put”). Put food. Tamil’s ordinary eat-verb is home-made; Malayalam’s is the family’s original.

Grammar Lens: -ഉക and -ഇക്കുക, two doors into the verb

Every verb so far has ended in -ഉക (-*uka*): *tinnuka*, *pōkuka*, *varuka*, *irikkuka*. Chapter 5’s “to speak” did not — it was സംസാരിക്കുക (*saṁsārikkuka*), with a longer -ഇക്കുക (-*ikkuka*). That difference is a passport stamp:

ending	what it marks
-ഉക - <i>uka</i>	an inherited Dravidian verb
-ഇക്കുക - <i>ikkuka</i>	a Sanskrit word made into a verb

Sanisārikkuka is built on Sanskrit *saṁsāra*; Chapter 9’s ക്ഷമിക്കുക (*kṣamikkuka*, “to forgive”) on *kṣamā*. Malayalam needed one dependable way to make a verb of any borrowed noun, and -ഇക്കുക is it: a naturalisation ceremony you can hear.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two eat-verbs — “tinnuka” (eat) and “uṇṇuka” (dine)
- the three times — “tinnunnu ... tinnu ... tinnuṁ”
- the cousins that kept the root — “tinu ... tinnu ... tinnuka”
- the two endings — “-uka is ours, -ikkuka came from Sanskrit”

Before you move on

Did Malayalam borrow its everyday word for eating? (**No** — Tamil is the one that built a new compound.) Which verb is for sitting down to a meal? (ഉണ്ണുക, *uṇṇuka*.) What does -*ikkuka* tell you? (**That the verb was made from a Sanskrit word.**) Next: a verb Malayalam kept where all three sisters walked away.

32.5 കാണുക (kāṇuka) — “to see,” and everything else the second slot can hold

Two slots, and the second one has only carried tense so far. It holds a good deal more — and you have used one of its other endings since Chapter 4.

What to know first

കാണുക — *kāṇuka* — to see, to meet

Present *kāṇunnu*, future *kāṇumī*, and a past that reshapes the way *vannu* did: കണ്ടു (*kaṇṭu*), “saw.”

You have said this verb in a goodbye. നാളെ കാണാം (*nāḷe kāṇām*) — “see you tomorrow” — is *nāḷe* (“tomorrow”) plus this stem with a different ending.

The letters in this word

കാ (*ka* with the long-*ā* sign) + ണു (retroflex *ṇu*) + ക (*ka*) → കാണുക. That ണ is the letter that ended *uṇṭū*: tongue curled back to the roof of the mouth.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Kāṇ- is the family’s own see-root, inherited from Proto-Dravidian — and here the four sisters part company. **Tamil** says പറ (*pār*), keeping കാண் (*kāṇ*) for formal writing; **Kannada** says ನೋಡು (*nōḍu*), keeping ಕಾಣು (*kāṇu*) alongside; **Telugu** says చూడు (*cūḍu*). Malayalam simply kept the inherited word in daily use. Twice now — *tinnuka* and *kāṇuka* — the youngest of the four sisters turns out to be the conservative one.

Grammar Lens: tense is only one thing that ending can be

Hold *kāṇ-* still and change what follows it:

ending on <i>kāṇ-</i>	what it says
<i>kāṇunnu</i>	sees, is seeing
<i>kāṇumī</i>	will see
<i>kāṇām</i>	may see; let’s see
<i>kāṇaṇam</i>	must see
<i>kāṇarutū</i>	must not see

Time, permission, obligation, prohibition — all in the same single slot. This is where the person ending went: Malayalam gave that slot up and spent the room on **mood** instead.

And the payoff lands on every line. *Kāṇaṇam* is “I must see,” “you must see” and “they must see” without changing a letter. In Tamil each of those five ideas must still pick a person ending before it can be said aloud.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kāṇuka” — to see — and the past, “kaṇṭu”
- the farewell you now understand — “nāḷe kāṇām”
- the ladder — “kāṇunnu ... kāṇum ... kāṇām ... kāṇaṇam ... kāṇarutū”
- one form, three people — “ñān, nī, avar ... kāṇaṇam”

Before you move on

Which of the four sisters kept the inherited see-word for everyday use? (**Malayalam** — the other three each chose a different word.) Say “must see” and “must not see.” (*Kāṇaṇam; kāṇarutū.*) What besides tense does that second slot carry? (**Mood** — permission, obligation, prohibition.) Next: the verb that moves the person out of the sentence altogether.

32.6 അറിയുക (*ariyuka*) — “to know,” the verb that takes no subject

Five verbs, and every one let you stand in front of it as *ñān*, “I.” The last one will not — and Chapter 6 already handed you the sentence it makes.

What to know first

അറിയുക — *ariyuka* — to know

Present *ariyunnu*, past അറിഞ്ഞു (*ariññu*), and the form you have met: അറിയാം (*ariyām*), with the *-ām* ending of the last lesson.

Native Dravidian, and the sisters kept the root — Tamil அறி (*ari*), Kannada ಅರಿ (*ari*) — though for everyday knowing each reached elsewhere: Tamil தெரியும் (*teriyum*), Telugu తెలుసు (*telusu*). Malayalam stayed with *ari-*.

The letters in this word

അ (the standing vowel *a*) + ി (*ri*) + യു (*yu*) + ക (*ka*) → അറിയുക.
 The റ is Malayalam’s hard, tapped *r*, a different letter and a different sound from the soft റ (*r*) of *varuka*.

Grammar Lens: the knower leaves the subject slot

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം. — *enikku malayāḷam ariyāṁ*
 — “I know Malayalam.”

Chapter 6 gave you that sentence whole. Here is the verb inside it. You cannot say *ñān malayāḷam ariyāṁ*: the one who knows is not the subject. That person moves into the **dative**, the “to me” case.

- *enikku ariyāṁ* — it is known **to me**
- *ninakku ariyāṁ* — it is known **to you**
- *avanŭ ariyāṁ* — it is known **to him**

Malayalam treats knowing as something that **arrives at** you rather than something you **do**, and marks it with the pronoun’s case.

That is the chapter’s closing symmetry. With the other five verbs the pronoun in front was the only thing telling you who acted, because the verb carried no person. Here it has changed case, so the sentence has no subject at all. Malayalam took the person off the verb; this construction takes it out of the subject slot too.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ariyuka*” — to know — and the past, “*ariññu*”
- “*enikku malayāḷam ariyāṁ*” — I know Malayalam
- three knowers, one verb — “*enikku ... ninakku ... avanŭ ariyāṁ*”
- the chapter’s six — “*uṇṭŭ, pōkunnu, varunnu, tinnunnu, kāṇunnu, ariyunnu*”

Before you move on

Say “I know Malayalam,” and name the case the “I” wears. (*Enikku malayāḷani ariyāni* — the **dative**.) Name the two slots of a Malayalam verb. (**Stem and tense**, with no third slot for person.) Which of the six verbs has an irregular past? (*Varuka* → *vannu*, and *kāṇuka* → *kaṇṭu*.) Which be-word says “I have”? (*ഉണ്ടു*, *uṇṭū*.) How many forms has the Malayalam present tense, for any verb at all? (**One**.)

The Malayalam script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** ക = ka, മ = ma, ര = ra.
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** കാ = k $\bar{a}$, കി = ki, കീ = k $\bar{i}$, കു = ku, കൂ = k $\bar{u}$, കെ = ke, കേ = k $\bar{e}$, കൊ = ko, കോ = k $\bar{o}$. (The *e/o* signs are written *before* their consonant but read after.)
3. **The *chandrakkala* strips the built-in vowel, and bare consonants join as conjuncts.** സ + ക → സ്ക (ska), ന + ദ → ന്ദ (nda), ല + ല → ല്ല (lla). A circle **anusvāram** ണ adds a final nasal.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

അ a · ആ ā · ഇ i · ഊ ī · ഉ u · ഊ ū · എ e · ഏ ē · ഐ ai ·
ഒ o · ഓ ō · ഔ au.

Worth flagging

- **The largest Dravidian alphabet.** Because Malayalam borrowed so heavily from Sanskrit, it keeps the full Sanskrit inventory — aspirates (ഖ kh, ധ dh...) and all three sibilants (ശ ś, ഷ ṣ, സ s) — alongside native Dravidian letters Tamil also has (the retroflex ള ḷ, ഴ ḻ, ഺ ṡ).
- **Rounded forms, many conjuncts.** Malayalam’s curved letters and rich stock of stacked/ligated conjuncts give it a distinctive dense look.

Malayalam in the Dravidian family

Dravidian is a family entirely separate from Indo-European (English, Latin, Sanskrit). Malayalam is the *closest sister of Tamil* — the two split from one language only about a thousand years ago — so its everyday core is strikingly Tamil-like (*nandi*, *illa*, *śari*, and the *pōyi varām* farewell). At the same time it absorbed a vast Sanskrit layer, which is why its formal greeting (*namaskāram*) and its full letter-set are Sanskritised. The lessons trace, word by word, what is inherited Dravidian and what is borrowed.